

Campaign Agendas and Issue Group Strategy in Intraparty Elections*

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Abstract

Which candidates do issue-focused groups support? Longstanding theories suggest an emphasis on either accessing friendly incumbents or helping elect new potential allies, yet systematic evaluation requires information on candidate-side issue priorities. I combine an original dataset of all available House primary candidates' policy platforms spanning 2016 through 2024 with FEC receipts and bill summaries to measure campaign attention, PAC contributions, and legislative behavior across 47,000 candidate-issue-year observations. Using a series of within-candidate research designs, I first demonstrate that candidates raise more money from groups related to their campaign issues. Leveraging changes in officeholder status, I then show that a substantially larger incumbency advantage in issue group fundraising is afforded to such "issue champions" — a difference not explained by actual legislative activity. These results provide new evidence that policy-demanding groups use campaign rhetoric to identify and foster relationships with potential champions of their cause during the increasingly important primary stage of congressional elections.

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Issue-centric groups constitute many of the most widely recognized and longstanding political spending organizations in U.S. elections. Interest groups focused on a particular issue area, such as Planned Parenthood, the Sierra Club, and the National Rifle Association, are fixtures in congressional elections which themselves receive millions of dollars in contributions from individuals who share the groups' issue priorities.¹ Literature on extended party networks suggests that such groups are especially active and influential in primary elections, where candidate differences are less salient and voter information is low (Bawn et al. 2012; Cohen et al. 2008). However, existing theories offer divergent predictions regarding how issue groups should use campaign contributions to achieve their policy goals, and candidate-side data limitations have hindered empirical efforts to assess them. This paper investigates how issue groups trade off between helping elect new potential champions of their cause and seeking access to friendly lawmakers.

Like corporate PACs, issue groups may generally fund incumbent candidates in hopes of “buying” favor, access, or influence (Denzau and Munger 1986; Gordon and Hafer 2005; Fourinaies and Hall 2014, 2018; Powell and Grimmer 2016; Snyder 1990). However, unlike obscure corporate regulations, candidates are more likely to have already decided the extent to which they care about the more salient issues upon which issue groups are formed, rendering contributions inefficient. In a similar vein to theories of lobbying, issue groups could instead target contributions to incumbents who have already signaled a commitment to their issue in order to induce greater effort (Hall and Wayman 1990; Hall and Deardorff 2006). However, to better ensure that they receive returns on their investments, group-centric theories of parties instead suggest that a more effective way for issue groups to achieve their policy goals is by helping to nominate and elect a true issue champion (Bawn et al. 2012).

One way for candidates to indicate their priorities is choosing to devote finite cam-

¹While I refer to them hereafter as *issue groups* or *issue PACs*, the same groups are elsewhere referred to as *single-issue interest groups* (e.g. Bonica 2013; Crosson, Furnas, and Lorenz 2020), *issue advocacy groups* (e.g. Phillips N.d.), or *activist groups* (e.g. Blum and Cowburn 2023).

campaign attention to an issue. However, limited data on candidates' issue priorities have prevented large-scale empirical studies of whether issue groups' primary contribution strategies are responsive to these potentially low-cost signals. An accounting of campaign issue priorities is especially elusive for large swaths of primary candidates due to the price of running television advertisements and the *de minimis* media coverage of the vast majority of primary races, which existing work typically uses to capture campaign agendas (Banda 2015; Sides 2007; Sulkin 2005; Sulkin, Moriarty, and Hefner 2007; Spiliotes and Vavreck 2002). Evaluating issue PACs' contribution strategies in primaries is especially important given the decline of two-party district competition (Abramowitz, Alexander, and Gunning 2006), yet few studies have systematically examined interest group giving in congressional primaries specifically.² By focusing on the primary stage, I advance our understanding of how issue groups select among co-partisans, a particularly relevant calculus given many issue groups' increasing alignment with one political party (Barber and Eatough 2019; Crosson, Furnas, and Lorenz 2020; Herrnson 2009; Lacombe 2019; Phillips N.d.).

To test the extent to which issue groups focus on access-buying versus helping elect new potential issue champions, I leverage an original collection of campaign platforms from the websites of candidates who ran in Democratic and Republican House primaries in 2016, 2018, 2020, 2022, and 2024. Combined with itemized contribution receipts, these textual data allow me to match campaign attention to interest group support across nine major issue areas: Guns, Abortion, Environment, Animal Rights, Police, Elderly, LGBTQ, Campaign Finance, and Israel.³ With observations at the candidate-issue-year level, I am able to employ a variety of within-candidate empirical approaches. First, I investigate whether candidates are more likely to receive contributions from PACs centered around their campaign priorities with candidate-year, issue-year, and district-issue fixed

²For some excellent exceptions, see Hassell (2016, 2023); Grumbach (2020); Patterson (N.d.).

³As discussed in Appendix E, I focus on issues which are sufficiently broad yet non-boilerplate, and whose interest groups' goals are primarily collective rather than particularistic.

effects. I also consider whether these effects vary by electoral context. Second, I further examine how issue groups respond to officeholding status and campaign prioritization of their issue by estimating a within-candidate incumbency advantage in fundraising from groups related to issues championed versus ignored as a non-incumbent. Third, I use a within-member design to assess the extent to which groups respond to legislators' campaign rhetoric versus legislative activity on their issue.

My results are consistent with issue groups relying on campaign rhetoric to identify potential issue champions during intraparty primary elections, and continuing to cultivate relationships with them once in Congress. Primary candidates are significantly more likely to receive contributions from groups centered around the issues on which they chose to campaign. Although they receive major boosts in issue group support after becoming incumbents, the increase is disproportionately concentrated among groups related to the issues they championed as non-incumbents. Moreover, this is not driven by legislative activity: while campaign attention credibly predicts legislative attention, issue group contributions are, if anything, more responsive to campaign attention to their issue than to legislative attention. While I cannot provide causal evidence that groups' contribution behavior responds directly to campaign rhetoric on their issue, I find little evidence that campaign rhetoric is merely cheap talk, that issue group support drives campaign attention, or that issue groups solely respond to campaign rhetoric on their issue because it proxies past or future behaviors that groups value.

This article makes four contributions to the study of interest groups, congressional elections, and legislative behavior in the United States. First, I join a growing literature elucidating the intraparty electoral dynamics in the United States (Blum and Cowburn 2023; Hassell 2023; Hirano and Snyder 2019; Lockhart and Hill 2023; Thomsen 2023). While research on congressional races has traditionally focused on the general election stage, the decline of two-party competition means that electoral outcomes are frequently determined at the primary stage. Second, I advance our understanding of the strategies adopted by

single-issue interest groups, which are widely recognizable fixtures in American elections yet are typically lumped together with general ideological interest groups (e.g. Bonica 2013; Grumbach 2020) and have received far less scholarly attention than corporate PACs and individual donors (e.g. Barber 2016; Fowler, Garro, and Spenkuch 2020; Kujala 2020; Meisels, Clinton, and Huber 2024; Thieme 2020). As such groups increasingly align with one party or the other, their real decision ultimately becomes *which* copartisans to support (Crosson, Furnas, and Lorenz N.d.). Third, I illuminate the beginnings of the legislator–group life cycle by investigating connections formed prior to entrance to office. Moving beyond legislator-group interactions within the legislative arena provides insight into how issue groups initially decide with whom to work. Finally, these findings provide evidence of the connection between electoral and legislative behavior in the current era, as well as an assessment of key stakeholders’ responses to each (Sulkin 2011; Schnakenberg 2016).

Theoretical Foundations of Issue Group Strategy

Although strong fundraising is no guarantee that a candidate will win an election, money is a prerequisite for any large-scale electioneering effort, enables the hiring of staff and consultants, and signals viability and strength — particularly in primary elections (Biersack, Herrnson, and Wilcox 1993; Epstein and Zemsky 1995; Jacobson 2015; Maestas and Rugeley 2008; Thomsen 2023). The importance of campaign contributions and the incentives that they create for candidate behavior are reflected by a sustained scholarly focus on the potentially distorting effects of money in politics (Canes-Wrone and Gibson 2019; Francia et al. 2003; Kalla and Broockman 2016; Kujala 2020; Powell 2012).

Issue groups have collective policy goals,⁴ and existing theories suggest different intra-party contribution strategies that such groups might employ to best achieve them. The first approach centers around seeking access to legislators directly, akin to corporate PACs con-

⁴This contrasts with corporate PACs, trade groups, and groups oriented around particularistic benefits for members which are tailored as narrowly as possible to their organization or sector.

tributing to legislators with the greatest policymaking influence over their industry (Fournaies and Hall 2014, 2018; Powell and Grimmer 2016; Romer and Snyder 1994). However, many electeds lack the technical expertise required to have well-formed opinions on relatively obscure regulations, the minutiae of which fly under the political radar and are also unlikely to activate the public (Arnold 1990; Denzau and Munger 1986). This contrasts with the more salient, controversial, and “easy” policies around which many issue groups are formed, making it less realistic to influence politicians’ behavior on the same. As such, formal theories of lobbying suggest that issue groups should target like-minded legislators in hopes of inducing greater effort on their mutual goals (Hall and Wayman 1990; Hall and Deardorff 2006). In the context of modern primary elections, issue priority may be a highly informative indicator of like-mindedness, as co-partisans tend to be on the same side of issues (Levendusky 2009).⁵

However, focusing contribution strategies on access to incumbents constrains issue groups to form relationships with those already in office, who may be insufficiently reliable allies. Group-centric theories of political parties suggest that a more efficient way to ensure a return on investment is by getting “a genuine friend nominated and elected to office” (Bawn et al. 2012, 575). Because of low participation and widespread voter apathy toward the relatively small differences between co-partisans, special interests are thought to exert especially strong influence at the primary stage (Bawn et al. 2023; Grumbach 2020; Hassell 2016; Karol 2009; Masket 2009).⁶ At the same time, co-partisans with relatively similar ideological stances can attempt to distinguish themselves via issue priorities. Because co-partisan (or co-ideologue) candidates are relatively unlikely to face opponents actively hostile to most of their general positions,⁷ polarized groups have a real opportu-

⁵For this reason, my analyses exclude nonpartisan or multiparty primaries (see Appendix C).

⁶Another key tenet of this theoretical tradition is coordination among coalitions of different interest groups (e.g. Cohen et al. 2008; Crosson, Furnas, and Lorenz N.d.; Hassell 2023; Patterson N.d.), which some have called into question (e.g. McCarty and Schickler 2018). While I largely set aside the possibility of such dynamics here, Figure 3 suggests some co-occurrence of primary contributions by different issue groups — but this does not appear to be related to co-occurrence of campaigning upon the different issues.

⁷For example, a modern pro-abortion Democratic candidate is relatively unlikely to face a Democratic primary opponent who is both anti-abortion and would exert substantial effort to enact anti-abortion policy.

nity to identify and support a true friend. By helping to elect a genuine issue ally whose priorities are aligned with theirs, groups can reduce the need for costly oversight, monitoring, and discipline (Stratmann 1998).

In most cases, however, identifying a true champion is no easy task for issue groups. Even for incumbents, who have records of activity in the relevant venue, it may be challenging to separate legislators' priorities from their strategic response to dynamics of agenda control (Cox and McCubbins 2005; Denzau and Mackay 1983), secular changes in windows of legislative opportunity on an issue (Jones and Baumgartner 2005; Krehbiel 1998; Romer and Rosenthal 1978), and individual ability to marshal bills through the legislative process (Hitt, Volden, and Wiseman 2017; Volden and Wiseman 2014). And while some non-incumbent congressional candidates have prior officeholding experience, the extent to which these records would predict future priorities in the federal legislative setting is unclear. Moreover, relying upon past records precludes comparison between candidates with and without prior officeholding experience.

Compared to other arenas, campaigns provide a relatively level playing field for candidates to more cleanly signal their issue priorities.⁸ Campaign platforms are selected on the basis of factors such as national and district issue salience, personal importance of an issue, and constituency composition (Druckman et al. 2010; Meisels 2025; Sides 2006; Spiliotes and Vavreck 2002). Candidates choosing of their own volition to campaign on an issue suggests that they find it important, whether for personal, electoral, or representational reasons. To the extent that there exist strategic constraints on the number of issues upon which candidates can or should campaign (perhaps because campaigning on fewer issues is more effective than campaigning on many), campaign attention can be expended to reveal their "type" — whether they are an issue champion or not — across issues.

Overall, whether and why groups would contribute to candidates espousing potentially low-cost campaign attention to their issue is a relatively open question. First, if

⁸This is true even for incumbents, who may be partially constrained by their past legislative activity.

groups believe that campaign rhetoric itself is cheap and is not indicative of more costly behaviors that they value, there is little reason to expect a relationship between campaign attention to an issue and support from groups related to that issue (e.g. Harrington 1992). Second, a relationship may exist not because campaign attention is itself valuable or provides independent information, but because it simply correlates with behavior in the past or in the immediate future that groups value, such as activity in Congress preceding or proceeding the election (Schnakenberg 2016; Sulkin 2009). Third, a relationship may exist because campaign prioritization provides some independent value or signal of longer term issue championship to groups. For example, groups may believe that increased salience resulting from their issue's prominence in campaigns will be beneficial for their policy or fundraising goals (Berry and Wilcox 2015; Kollman 1998).

Related to this, existing theories also diverge in their expectations about whether issue groups should respond more strongly to incumbents' versus non-incumbents' issue priorities. If issue PACs most value access to friendly lawmakers, responsiveness to incumbents' issue priorities should be especially strong. This could either be due to the reinforcing relationship between campaign and legislative priorities (Sulkin and Swigger 2008; Sulkin 2009, 2011), or the informativeness of rhetoric itself as a less-mediated signal of incumbents' priorities (Druckman, Kifer, and Parkin 2009). Moreover, incumbents' *a priori* higher likelihood of election to office than non-incumbents (Abramowitz, Alexander, and Gunning 2006) heightens the stakes of their campaign rhetoric due to increased possibility of electoral accountability in the subsequent election.⁹ Conversely, group-centric theories of party nominations suggest that the effect of campaign issue attention on issue group support should be strongest among non-incumbents. Precisely because non-incumbents do not have prominent officeholding records, campaign rhetoric may constitute an especially important source of information for issue groups to draw on when seeking to identify new issue champions.

⁹This remains true even at very low levels of future accountability.

The extent to which issue groups prioritize access-seeking versus electing new potential issue allies also suggests different levels of responsiveness to campaign priorities by district competitiveness. If issue groups most value access to like-minded legislators, their contributions should be more strongly influenced by shared priorities in districts safer for candidates' parties. Similar to the logic of corporate PAC funds flowing disproportionately to electorally advantaged candidates (Fouirnaies and Hall 2014), those in safe districts face a more certain victory in the general election. This means that issue groups can attempt to financially bolster candidates during the primary, after which the electoral outcome is relatively secured. If issue groups instead prioritize electing new issue allies, they should gamble on candidates in competitive districts who share their priorities, as these contributions have the greatest marginal impact on legislative composition all else equal. Moreover, this riskier strategy can potentially offer a higher return on investment, as nominees are in greater need of a financial edge in competitive general elections.¹⁰

To summarize, existing theories offer different predictions about issue group contribution strategy in partisan primaries. Access-centered approaches suggest that issue groups should target incumbents and electorally safe primary candidates who have demonstrated shared issue priority. Group-centric theories of parties instead suggest that issue groups should prioritize electing new issue champions by targeting non-incumbents and primary candidates in competitive districts who have demonstrated shared issue priority. However, the extent to which issue groups should rely upon candidates' rhetoric to identify issue allies is also unclear. While incumbents' campaign platforms may reflect their real legislative priorities, other candidates' platforms could be too "cheap" to constitute meaningful signals of issue priorities.

¹⁰Primary-designated contributions not spent during the primary election are legally allowed to go toward general election expenditures.

Data

Assessing relationships between campaign issue attention and issue group support in primaries first requires identifying issues of interest. I focus on nine issues — Guns, Abortion, Environment, Animal Rights, Police, Elderly, LGBTQ, Campaign Finance, and Israel — which met a few important criteria. First, they are broad and mainstream enough for PACs to have formed around them and for candidates across the nation to meaningfully consider whether or not to campaign upon them.¹¹ Second, the issues are narrow enough that candidates do not feel uniformly compelled to take boilerplate positions on them.¹² Finally, the interest groups formed around these issues are not predominantly concerned with their members' material interests, as is the case with union and trade groups, whose structures and goals are known to be distinct from those of other issue groups (Barber and Eatough 2019; Phillips N.d.; Welch 1980). Further information about the issue selection process is provided in Appendix A.

I capture House primary candidates' issue group support using transaction-level receipts of PACs' primary-designated campaign contributions from the Federal Election Commission (FEC). To identify primary contributions made by PACs focused on one of the nine issues of interest, I merge the FEC data with OpenSecrets' data on PAC issues/industries. All included PACs and their respective issue areas are listed in Appendix B.¹³ While detailed administrative data on campaign contributions is readily available, capturing candidate-side issue priority is a greater challenge. The cost of television advertisements, which previous studies have used to examine campaign priorities (Banda 2015; Sides 2006, 2007;

¹¹For example, platforms which include curbing the invasiveness of Asian carp (or Copi) are highly localized to areas around the Mississippi River and the Great Lakes, and no PACs are currently formed around the issue.

¹²For example, campaigning on macroeconomic policy — such as taxes and government spending — is so widespread that economic policy PACs are likely precluded from considering whether to factor issue attention into their strategies.

¹³I do not exclude PACs whose names suggest geographic locations, as most are cases where PAC backers are concentrated in a given location yet the PAC contributes to candidates beyond the geographic area. However, in Appendix F I show that results are robust to their exclusion.

Sides and Karch 2008; Sulkin and Swigger 2008; Sulkin 2009, 2011; Spiliotes and Vavreck 2002), is prohibitive for most House primary candidates and not a worthy investment for those in all but the most competitive races. Others have employed media coverage of campaigns to identify candidates' issue priorities (Sulkin 2005), yet these characterizations of campaign priorities are mediated by a third party and, likewise, only offer coverage of races that clear some threshold of newsworthiness.

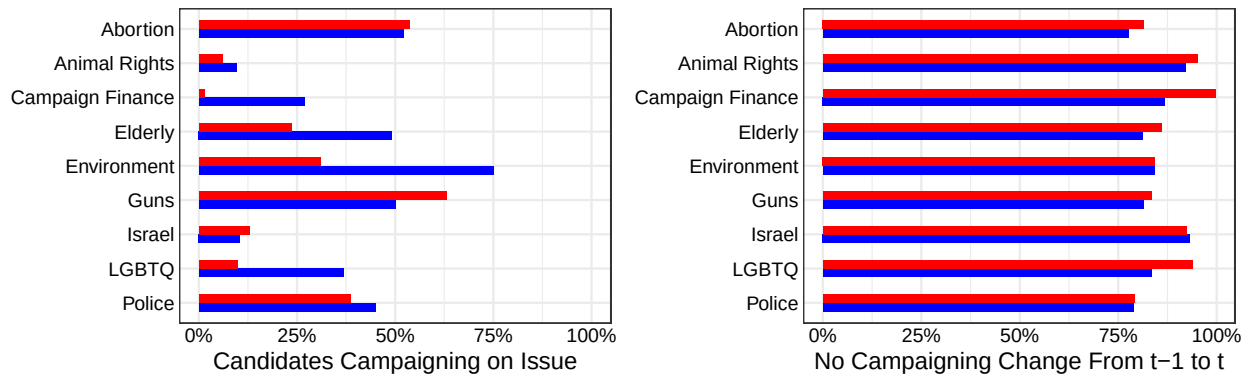
Instead, I collect issue platform text on all available campaign websites of candidates who appeared on a Democratic or Republican House primary ballot from 2016 to 2024.¹⁴ Campaign website platforms constitute a uniquely well-suited source of data on primary candidates' issue priorities. The vast majority of websites contain a page or section clearly delineated as a collection of issue stances, resembling a stated policy platform more closely than any other campaign activity. Additionally, the priorities and positions found on websites are selected and articulated by candidates themselves,¹⁵ in contrast to media interviews, televised debates, and newspaper writeups. Websites also provide candidates an opportunity to present a more comprehensive campaign platform than purchased advertisements in newspapers or on television (Sulkin, Moriarty, and Hefner 2007). Finally, creating and maintaining a website is easy and far cheaper than fundraising, sending mailers, and running television advertisements, making campaign platforms a more inclusive data source with regard to candidates' resources. For these reasons, scholars have long recognized candidate websites' value for studying campaign strategy in general (e.g. McDonald, Porter, and Treul 2020; Nyhan and Montgomery 2015) and issue platforms in particular (Druckman et al. 2010; Milita, Ryan, and Simas 2014).¹⁶

¹⁴This effort includes over 7,000 unique candidate-year observations, 75% (5,311) of which hosted campaign websites with issue content. Appendix C provides a detailed explication and examples of each step of the data collection process, as well as evidence of the representativeness of candidates with and without platforms. Unsurprisingly, incumbents and those who garnered more than a *de minimis* share of their primary field's total fundraising create websites with campaign platforms at a higher rate. However, the magnitude of missingness among candidates without viable fundraising is actually quite modest considering the large portion of non-incumbents who did not even file a pre-primary fundraising report.

¹⁵This remains true in the case of political consultant influence (e.g. Nyhan and Montgomery 2015), as candidates can ultimately fire consultants advocating strategies with which they disagree.

¹⁶As noted by Druckman, Kifer, and Parkin, campaign websites "provide an unmediated, holistic, and

Figure 1. Campaign Agenda Issue Prevalence and Continuity

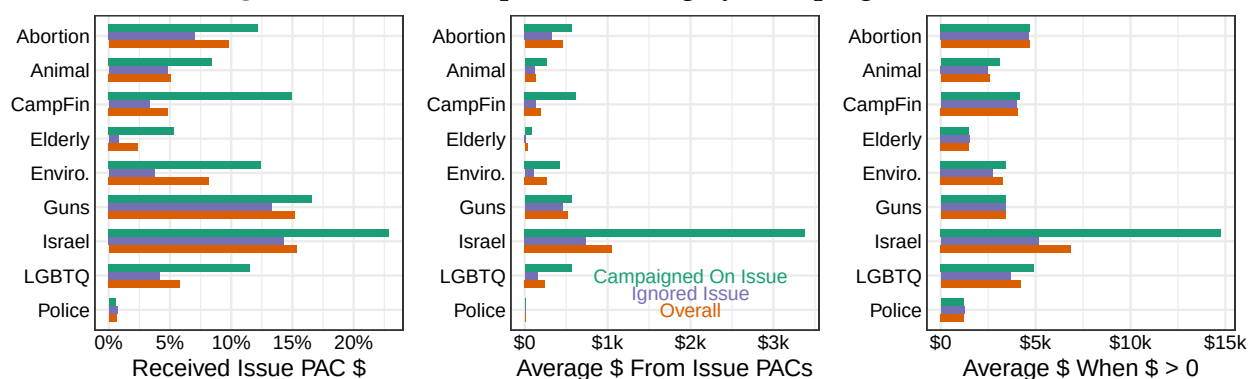


Note: Shares of candidate–year observations including issue in platform and candidates with platforms in consecutive campaigns who did not add or delete issue. Republicans in red and Democrats in blue.

To identify whether campaign platforms devoted attention to the nine issues of interest, keyword dictionaries associated with each issue were constructed using an approach similar to that of King, Lam, and Roberts (2017), which were then string-matched in the platform text. For example, terms like 2nd amendment, nra, rifle, ammunition, firearm, gun, and shooting were used to identify whether a platform devoted attention to the issue of Guns. Appendix E reports details of the keyword selection process, complete issue dictionaries, and a leave-one-out sensitivity analysis. Candidates’ rates of campaigning on each of the nine issues are displayed on the left side of Figure 1. There is substantial heterogeneity in issue prevalence both between and within parties. As an example of the former, Democrats out-campaigned Republicans on LGBTQ and environmental issues, consistent with work on partisan differences in issue coalitions and perceived “ownership” (Banda 2016; Lacombe 2019; Noel 2012). As an example of the latter, far fewer Democrats campaigned on campaign finance than on the environment. The intra-party differences in attention across issues, as well as most rates falling far short of 100%, suggest that even candidates of the same party did not consistently campaign on the same issues.

In addition to the significant individual-level variation across issues implied by the left panel of Figure 1, the right panel also reveals considerable individual-level temporal stability *within* issues. From one election to the next, over 75% of candidates in both parties representative portrait of messages aimed at voters in general” (2009, 346-347).

Figure 2. Issue Group Fundraising by Campaign Attention



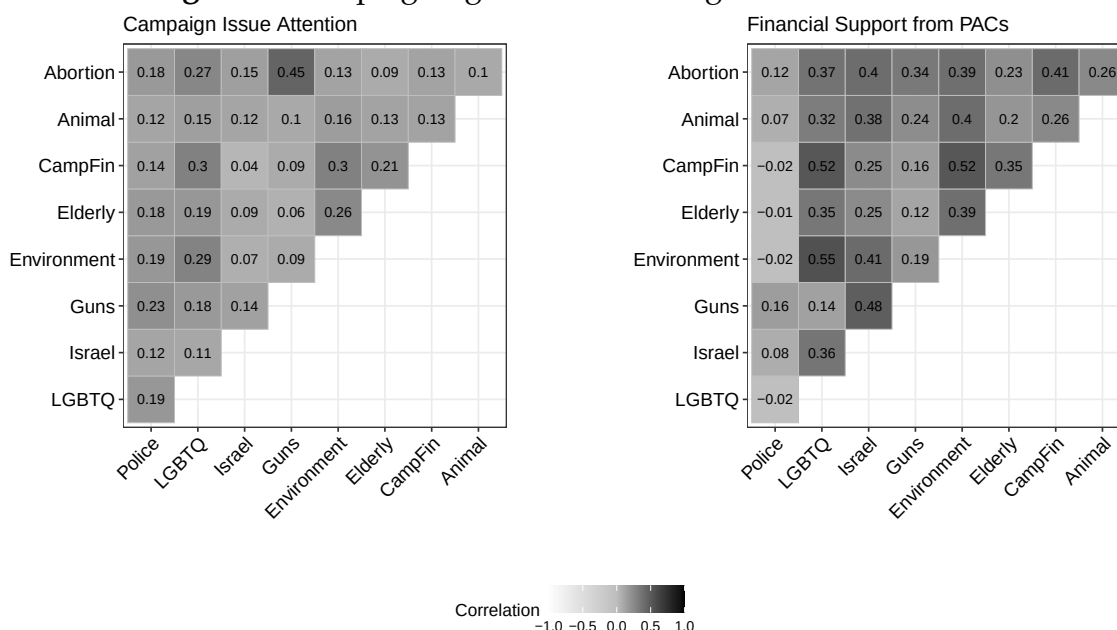
Note: Rightmost facet plots average amount among candidates who received a contribution.

maintained their choice to campaign on or omit each of the nine issues. In other words, if candidates choose to announce a position on an issue (or not) in a given election, they are empirically likely to make the same choice again in the following election. This suggests that issue agendas may be similar to roll-call voting in that they are a relatively static characteristic rather than a highly dynamic behavior (Poole and Rosenthal 1997).¹⁷

Figure 2 plots primary election contributions from groups across issue areas by whether recipient candidates campaigned on the issue and overall. Across each issue area, the three subplots provide descriptive, aggregate-level evidence that issue groups offer more financial support to candidates who choose to campaign on their issue. First, the left plot shows that the share of candidates receiving contributions from issue groups is consistently higher among candidates who campaigned on the issue compared to candidates who did not. Additionally, the center plot demonstrates that on average, candidates who campaign on an issue receive more total funds from groups related to the issue than candidates who did not campaign on the issue. However, as evidenced by the left plot, these averages include a large number of candidates who did not receive contributions from groups focused on a given issue. On the right side, even conditional on receiving contributions, those who campaigned on the issue often receive greater amounts compared to

¹⁷This might be the case because candidates' motivations for campaigning on issues — due to personal or constituency importance — remain relatively stable from election to election. Candidates may also seek to avoid potentially negative electoral consequences of positioning change, especially on these mostly “principled” issues (Tavits 2007).

Figure 3. Campaigning and Fundraising Issue Correlations



those who ignored the issue.

When examining the relationship between campaign attention to and contributions from groups related to particular issues, it is important to also consider potential relationships between different issues within the realms of both activities. There may be issues which simply “go together” in that candidates who tend to campaign on Issue *A* also tend to campaign on Issue *B*, and Issue *A* groups also tend to give to similar candidates as Issue *B* groups. Figure 3 assesses this possibility by presenting pairwise correlations between campaigning on different issue areas as well as receiving funds from groups related to different issue areas. Unsurprisingly, most correlations are positive, suggesting that candidates who tend to campaign on any of these issues also tend to campaign on the others, and that candidates who raise funds from groups related to one issue tend to raise funds from groups related to others. However, the correlations are not overwhelmingly strong. The strongest campaign attention correlation is between guns and abortion at 0.45, and correlations between attention to other issues are far smaller. Moreover, while the issue

group funding correlation is slightly above 0.5 for a few issues, there does not appear to be much overlap between issue areas with the strongest correlations in the realms of campaign attention and financial support. At minimum, this casts doubt on the idea that a spurious relationship between campaign priorities and fundraising could arise simply due to certain issues “going together” in both domains.

Issue Group Response to Campaign Rhetoric

Aggregate descriptive patterns suggest that candidates receive greater financial support from issue groups related to their campaign priorities, but this is likely due in part to differences across candidates and district contexts. For instance, it may be the case that candidate quality drives both issue focus in campaigns and fundraising success. I leverage a within-candidate design which relies upon cross-issue variation *within* candidates’ campaigns in a given year to investigate whether campaigning on an issue in partisan primaries is associated with greater issue group support. I estimate the following equation:

$$\text{Contribution}_{ijt} = \beta \text{CampaignAttention}_{ijt} + \alpha_{it} + \phi_{jt} + \lambda_{dj} + \epsilon_i. \quad (1)$$

On the left-hand side, $\text{Contribution}_{ijt}$ indicates whether candidate i received any contributions from groups associated with issue j during the primary election in year t . While candidate-PAC-year is the more natural level of giving, aggregating up to the candidate-issue-year level helps to minimize potential biases induced by the possibility of PACs within the same issue area coordinating their giving strategies — e.g. serving as strategic substitutes — or some PACs adopting rules against giving to certain types of candidates or in certain types of races.¹⁸ It also helps to equalize cases where candidates and groups

¹⁸Appendix G replicates all results at the candidate-PAC-year level.

are on different sides of an issue.¹⁹ The key independent variable $\text{CampaignAttention}_{ijt}$ indicates whether candidate i campaigned on issue j in primary election t . Candidate–year fixed effects α_{it} remove all observed and unobserved candidate–year–level factors that shape PAC fundraising uniformly across issue areas. For example, this accounts for candidates’ overall fundraising capacity, viability, or name recognition in a given cycle as long as groups respond commonly to these considerations. Standard errors are clustered at the candidate level.

By holding candidate–year fixed, β is identified from variation within a candidate’s primary campaign in a given year, comparing PAC support across issues on which she did and did not campaign. However, α_{it} does not absorb factors that vary across issues within the same candidate–year, such as a candidate’s issue–specific expertise or credibility, nor does it eliminate confounders that operate at the issue–year or district–issue level. Issue–year fixed effects ϕ_{jt} address the former by absorbing time–varying, issue–specific shocks — like the elevated salience of guns following high–profile mass shootings or abortion following *Dobbs* in 2022 (Meisels 2025; Reny et al. 2023) — which could simultaneously influence campaign attention and PAC giving on a given issue in a given year.

District–issue fixed effects λ_{dj} absorb time–invariant, district–level differences in issue salience or constituency demand — for instance, a coastal district’s preoccupation with environmental policy — which could similarly drive both campaign rhetoric and group contributions on the issue among candidates who ran in the same district. Together, these controls narrow the set of explanations for the observed relationship by ruling out general, issue–agnostic differences across different primary campaigns, issue–specific national trends, and stable district–level constituency pressures. It is important to note, however, that none of these fixed effects address potential confounders that vary within candidate–year, across issues, and which differentially affect candidates who have run in the same

¹⁹For example, cases where a candidate campaigns on abortion in a pro-life manner and receives contributions from pro-life groups and cases where a candidate campaigns on abortion in a pro-choice way and receives contributions from pro-choice groups will look equivalent.

district. For example, if incumbency leads candidates to devote more attention to particular issues and PACs focused on those issues respond more strongly to incumbency than PACs focused on other issues, that confounding will be unaccounted for.

Table 1 reports linear probability model estimates of Equation 1 across all combinations of fixed effects. Column 1, the simplest specification, communicates the core descriptive relationship most straightforwardly: candidates who campaigned on a given issue were 5.3 percentage points more likely than those who did not to receive funds from groups related to the issue. For substantive context, the baseline contribution rate across all among candidate–issue–year cases in which candidates ignored an issue is just 5.8%. This implies that campaigning on an issue corresponds to a nearly 100% proportional increase over the baseline. The remaining columns layer in fixed effects in order to assess whether this basic relationship survives under progressively narrower comparisons, the isolation of different sources of variation, and the ruling out of alternative explanations. Columns 2–4 introduce each fixed effect in isolation, Columns 5–7 include them in pairs, and Column 8 includes all three.

The largest perturbation in the estimate occurs when candidate–year fixed effects are added (Columns 2, 5, 7, and 8). This within–candidate comparison directly addresses a glaring alternative explanation for the Column 1 estimate: more skilled or higher–quality candidates simultaneously campaign on more issues and attract more PAC support across the board. The fact that the coefficient remains both sizable and statistically significant under this comparison indicates that the relationship is not simply an artifact of cross–candidate differences. Issue–year fixed effects (Columns 3, 5, 6, and 8) further ensure that the estimate is not driven by years in which a particular issue was nationally prominent for both candidates and PACs, while district–issue fixed effects (Columns 4, 6, 7, and 8) absorb persistent, district–level variation in issue salience, addressing the concern that the relationship reflects geographic constituencies which consistently demand both campaign attention and attract group activity on a given issue. The most saturated specification in

Table 1. Relationship Between Issue Attention and Financial Support from Issue Groups

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)							
Campaigned on Issue	0.053*** (0.004)	0.040*** (0.003)	0.054*** (0.005)	0.050*** (0.004)	0.038*** (0.004)	0.050*** (0.004)	0.035*** (0.003)	0.034*** (0.003)
Candidate-Year FE		✓			✓		✓	✓
Issue-Year FE			✓		✓	✓		✓
District-Issue FE				✓		✓	✓	✓
Observations	47,799	47,799	47,799	47,790	47,799	47,790	47,790	47,790
Unique Candidates	4,082	4,082	4,082	4,081	4,082	4,081	4,081	4,081
Unique Districts	363	363	363	362	363	362	362	362

Note: Observations are candidate–issue–year. Candidate–clustered standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Column 8 still implies that campaigning on an issue is associated with more than a 50% increase over the baseline likelihood of issue group support, even when relying solely on within-candidate-year variation that remains unexplained by issue-specific temporal shocks and issue-specific differences across districts.

One potential explanation for this observed relationship is that the sequence of events may actually be reversed: primary candidates receive a contribution from an issue group, prompting them to take up that issue in their campaign. Because I only capture a snapshot of each campaign platform immediately before respective primary dates, I cannot directly track platform changes in relation to contribution timing. However, in addition to the platform stability shown in Figure 1 suggesting that issue attention tends not to be dynamic, in Appendix D I uncover patterns inconsistent with relationship reversal. First, I find little evidence that candidates who receive issue PAC contributions devote more attention to those issues in the subsequent election. Second, issue PAC contributions are disproportionately concentrated in the post-filing period and closer to the primary date, when candidates are most likely to have solidified their platform. Third, the relationship between campaign attention and issue group fundraising persists when including only these later post-filing contributions, as well as when selecting on cases where candidates' attention to an issue appears stable across elections. Moreover, I show that results hold among when excluding candidates most safely assumed to advance to the general election

or including only primaries in districts safe for the party, suggesting that results are not merely driven by groups looking forward to the general election.

Beyond demonstrating that candidates are generally more likely to receive financial support from groups related to their campaign issue priorities, we can also examine whether such a relationship exists with regard to continuous measures of candidates' issue prioritization and financial support. In Appendix F, I show that the basic relationship is robust to operationalizing campaign issue attention with number of issue related terms included in the platform, or operationalizing issue group support as logged contribution amount, as well as including only candidates with variation in financial support across issue areas (Beck 2020). Moreover, subgroup analyses demonstrate that both Democrats and Republicans are more likely to receive financial support from groups related to their campaign issues (Appendix H), and while the relationship remains statistically significant at traditional levels across most of the separate issue areas, abortion, Israel, and campaign finance stand out as the strongest (Appendix I).²⁰

Issue Group Strategy: Campaign Rhetoric and Access

Having demonstrated a general relationship between issue campaign attention and issue group fundraising in partisan primaries, I evaluate competing theoretical predictions about where this relationship should be largest. In particular, access-centered approaches suggest that such relationships should be strongest among incumbents and those in safe districts, while group-centric theories of parties suggest strongest relationships among non-incumbents and in competitive districts. I re-estimate Equation 1 separately by candidate type and district competitiveness, with the latter following Hirano and Snyder (2019)'s categorization of swing districts as those where the party's nominee received between 42.5% and 57.5% of the two-party vote share in the most recent presidential election.

²⁰Issue-specific analyses should be interpreted with caution, as they must rely on cross-candidate variation and include only party-year fixed effects.

These heterogeneous estimates should be interpreted more cautiously than those reported in Table 1 for two reasons. First, I omit district–issue fixed effects due to a lack of relevant variation when subsetting to incumbents.²¹ Second, comparing estimates across models subset by candidate and district characteristics effectively re-introduces the differences which candidate–year fixed effects accounted for in Table 1. I address the limitations of this approach in subsequent analyses.

Overall, Table 2 suggests that the relationship between campaign issue attention and financial support from issue groups exists across candidate and district types.²² While coefficient sizes appear larger among incumbents than non-incumbents, proportional increases relative to baselines are substantially greater among non-incumbents. Baseline rates imply that, in swing districts, campaigning on an issue is associated with an increase in the likelihood of issue group contributions of around 50% for incumbents, 100% for open–seat candidates, and 90% for challengers.²³ In districts leaning toward one party, incumbents see about a 60% increase while the increase is 100% and 140% for open–seat candidates and challengers, respectively.²⁴ Although the *absolute* increase in issue PAC funding associated with campaign attention is greatest among incumbents, the proportional increases relative to baselines appear to be roughly twice as large for non-incumbents. Finally, comparing levels of district competitiveness within candidate types suggest only modest differences between swing versus leaning districts.

Subsetting by candidate type in Table 2 can also potentially shed light on mechanisms behind issue groups’ support of those who campaign on their issue. As discussed previously, a relationship between campaign attention and issue group support could simply reflect groups’ foreknowledge of which candidates are issue champions even prior to the primary election, rather than campaign rhetoric serving as valuable information for

²¹This is due to the fact that few districts featured multiple unique incumbents across the period.

²²For ease of interpretation, I focus on binary specifications of the independent and dependent variables, with estimates from other specifications in Table 1 reported in Appendix F.

²³Respectively, their baseline rates are 0.291, 0.023, and 0.018.

²⁴These baseline rates are 0.215, 0.018, and 0.005.

Table 2. Relationship Between Issue Attention and Financial Support From Issue Groups by Candidate and District Type

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)					
	Incumbents		Open Seat		Challengers	
	Swing	Lean	Swing	Lean	Swing	Lean
Campaigned on Issue	0.147*** (0.019)	0.126*** (0.014)	0.024** (0.007)	0.019*** (0.005)	0.016*** (0.004)	0.007*** (0.002)
Candidate-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,934	6,867	5,058	7,065	9,666	16,209
Unique Candidates	195	358	553	776	990	1,631
Unique Districts	135	276	73	115	152	292

Note: Observations are candidate–issue–year. Candidate–clustered standard errors in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

groups who are uncertain about candidates' loyalties. If this is the case, a consistent relationship should only be present among candidates who are likely already known quantities. Whereas incumbents have prior legislative records in the relevant venue, the overwhelming majority of non-incumbents running in House primary elections do not have similarly prominent reputations. The fact that the relationship between campaign attention and issue group support holds consistently among open seat candidates and challengers suggests that the basic relationship established in Table 1 is not solely explained by issue groups' foreknowledge of candidates' legislative issue championship. Moreover, in Appendix F I show that the relationship also holds among first-time congressional candidates, further suggesting that groups' financial support of those who champion their issue in an election does not merely reflect candidates' issue championship in a prior congressional run.

A tension in interpreting Table 2 arises because relationships between campaign attention and issue group support appear larger among incumbents or non-incumbents depending on the use of absolute versus proportional increases relative to baselines. This ambiguity results from incumbents' and non-incumbents' vastly different baseline rates of receiving issue PAC contributions, which highlights the difficulty of comparing the kinds of candidates who typically win to the the kinds of candidates who typically lose. To ad-

dress this limitation, I estimate a within-candidate financial incumbency advantage from groups related to issues she did versus did not champion. To do so, I compare the same candidate's support before and after she was elected, from groups related to issues she campaigned upon versus ignored as a non-incumbent. The specification is as follows:

$$f(\text{Contribute}_{ijt}) = \beta_1 \text{Incumbency}_{it} + \beta_2 \text{Campaigned}_{ijt-1} + \beta_3 (\text{Incumbency}_{it} \times \text{Campaigned}_{ijt-1}) + \alpha_i + \phi_{jt} + \epsilon_i. \quad (2)$$

The two outcomes represented by $f(\text{Contribute}_{ijt})$ capture binary and logged transformations of candidate i 's primary contributions from PACs related to issue j in year t . The main independent variables indicate whether candidate i ran as an incumbent in year t , campaigned on issue j during her primary election in year $t-1$, and their interaction. To best align with the key estimand — the difference in incumbency advantage in primary fundraising from groups associated with issues that the candidate ignored versus campaigned upon as a non-incumbent — I include candidates who ran in consecutive years and were either always non-incumbents (the reference or "control" group) or went from non-incumbents to incumbents, dropping re-election runs after their first. This ensures that in all cases, lagged campaign attention captures campaign priorities prior to any subsequent influence of legislative priorities.

This sample restriction, as well as the inclusion of candidate and issue-year fixed effects in Equation 2, means that β_1 estimates a within-candidate incumbency advantage in primary fundraising from groups related to issues she ignored before her election to office. Specifically, β_1 captures how a candidate's financial support from issue groups unrelated to her prior campaign priorities changes after she becomes an incumbent. Conversely, β_2 estimates the same candidate's change in contributions from groups related to her prior campaign priorities over the period in which she was not an incumbent. Lastly, the sum

of all three β coefficients represents the within-candidate incumbency advantage in primary fundraising from groups related to issues championed as a non-incumbent, with the sum of β_2 and β_3 capturing any additional financial incumbency advantage accrued on the basis of prior issue championship.

Unlike the models employed previously, which isolate within-candidate-year variation across issues, Equation 2 relies upon within-candidate variation across both issues and time. The temporal component is required for identification of within-candidate change in incumbency status, and cross-issue variation is required to compare the incumbency advantage in issue group fundraising across issues the candidate previously championed versus ignored. Within candidate, incumbency status varies temporally but is constant across issues, and campaign attention varies across issues but is highly stable across time. As in prior models, the fixed effects ensure results are not driven by general (i.e. time- and issue-agnostic) differences across candidates nor issue-specific time trends. However, in addition to the aforementioned candidate-issue level factors which could potentially confound the relationships reported earlier, the temporal variation required for estimation of Equation 2 introduces potential time-varying confounders as well.

The results in Table 3 suggest that while candidates receive general increases in issue group fundraising after entering Congress, there is a disproportionate financial incumbency advantage from groups related to issues championed as non-incumbents. After winning election to office, candidates are about 15 percentage points more likely to receive primary contributions from groups related to issues they ignored as non-incumbents. While the financial advantages of incumbency are well known, this result is notable in light of previous findings emphasizing that such advantages are driven by access-seeking corporate PACs (Fouirnaies and Hall 2014). Beyond this general incumbency advantage in issue group funding, however, candidates are significantly more likely to receive contributions from groups related to the issues they championed as non-incumbents compared to groups related to the issues that they ignored. Combining all three coefficients sug-

Table 3. Incumbency Advantage in Issue Group Financial Support By Prior Issue Attention

	DV: Contribution (0/1)	DV: log(Contribution + 1)
Incumbency	0.154** (0.047)	1.130** (0.369)
Campaigned on Issue $t-1$	0.028*** (0.007)	0.235*** (0.061)
Incumbency $\times$ Issue $t-1$	0.071** (0.026)	0.644** (0.205)
Candidate FE	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓
Observations	5,589	5,589
Unique Candidates	538	538
Unique Districts	266	266

Note: Observations are candidate–issue–year. Includes candidates who were non-incumbents at $t - 1$. Candidate–clustered standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

gests that candidates are over 25 percentage points more likely to receive financial support from groups related to their prior campaign priorities after winning election to office — 10 percentage points higher than the boost from groups related to issues they ignored. In terms of contribution amounts, the coefficients from the second column likewise imply that incumbency is associated with a 200% increase in contributions from groups related to issues ignored by a candidate before election and a nearly 650% increase from groups related to issues she championed. These estimates suggest that after candidates are successfully elected to office, they receive substantially greater financial support in their first re-election campaign from groups connected to their pre-election campaign priorities than from groups related to the issues they ignored.

Legislative and Financial Implications of Campaign Rhetoric

Taken together, the findings presented thus far are consistent with issue groups supporting candidates in partisan primaries who prioritize their issue during the campaign, particularly sitting legislators who championed their issue as non-incumbents. While Table 2 provided evidence that the general relationship between campaign attention and issue

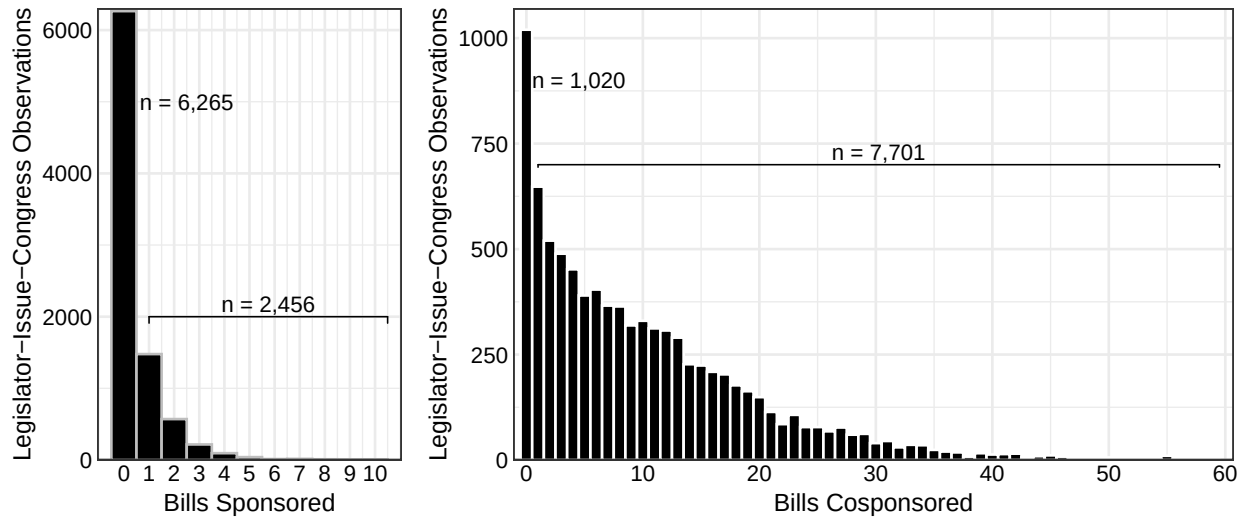
group support is not solely driven by candidates with existing records in Congress, the greater incumbency advantage in funding from groups related to issues championed as a non-incumbent shown in Table 3 may be due to legislative activity rather than campaign rhetoric. Specifically, candidates may campaign upon the issues they intend to prioritize in office, follow through by disproportionately focusing on such issues in the next Congress, and then receive greater financial support from groups related to those issues in the next election — not because of their prior campaign attention, but because of their legislative attention to the issues. This would be the case if campaign rhetoric provides no value to issue groups independent of its relationship with legislative activity.

On the other hand, the findings in Table 3 may be consistent with groups responding to campaign rhetoric itself. As discussed previously, groups may believe that increased salience of their issue is beneficial for policy or fundraising reasons. Moreover, although campaign rhetoric is “cheap” in that it likely requires less effort than sponsoring or even cosponsoring legislation, public opinion and electoral accountability stakes may be higher than for the vast majority of legislative activity.²⁵ Campaign rhetoric may also provide a clearer signal of longer term intentions on an issue than short term legislative activity such as (co)sponsorship, as platforms typically combine discrete legislative goals with wider-ranging principles, while standalone bills tend to be more limited in scope.²⁶ For these reasons, campaign rhetoric may actually provide a clearer and more meaningful signal of longer-term issue championship than most cases of sponsorship or cosponsorship, especially in polarized eras where most bills on contentious issues are essentially dead upon

²⁵While it is doubtful that most voters — much less most constituents — are aware of their representative’s campaign website content, awareness of sponsorship or cosponsorship activity is surely many times smaller, especially in light of the miniscule number of bills which receive any meaningful committee consideration.

²⁶For example, Keith Self’s campaign platform in 2022, when he was first elected to represent TX-3, included the following abortion-related rhetoric: *PRO-LIFE: Keith believes in the sanctity and value of every human life. The sonogram is the greatest tool in our fight against the barbarism and child sacrifice of the abortion industry. In Congress, Keith will fight to protect the Hyde Amendment and finally defund Planned Parenthood.* In the subsequent 118th congress, the one abortion-related bill which Rep. Self sponsored was H.R.10349 - Ensuring Justice for Victims of Partial-Birth Abortion Act, which called for an investigation of whether the remains of babies discovered by D.C. police in 2022 were a violation of the federal partial-birth abortion ban, and proposed mandatory reporting and investigation of violations of the ban.

Figure 4. Congress-Specific Rates of Legislators Sponsoring and Cosponsoring Issue Bills



Note: Histograms binning the number of legislators who sponsored (left) and cosponsored (right) each number of bills on a given issue in a single Congress. Annotation reports the number of legislators who did and did not sponsor and cosponsor any bills on an issue in a given Congress.

arrival (Jones and Baumgartner 2005; Krehbiel 1998; Lee 2016).

To investigate the extent to which campaign attention predicts legislative attention and how issue groups respond to both, I compile data on bill summaries, sponsors, and cosponsors from the `govinfo.gov` Bulk Data Repository to supplement the campaign platform and issue group contribution data. Applying a dictionary string-matching approach to the bill summary text similar to that employed in the campaign platform text, I identify whether each H.R. introduced during the 115th through 118th congresses²⁷ pertained to the nine issue areas of interest. Figure 4 shows the distribution of number of bills sponsored and cosponsored by members in a given congress on a given issue. Across all combinations of legislators, congresses, and issues, the overall rate of sponsorship was 28% over the period, and members who sponsored any bills on an issue tended to sponsor just one. On the other hand, the overall cosponsorship rate was 88%, with a median of 9 and a standard deviation of 10 bills cosponsored among legislator-congress-issue cases with any cosponsorship activity.

²⁷ Although the sample includes candidates elected in 2024, the 119th congress does not end until 2027.

To assess whether the incumbency advantage differences found in Table 3 are more consistent with issue groups responding to campaign rhetoric itself or solely due to its relationship with legislative activity, I perform two sets of analyses. First, I investigate whether campaign attention is in fact predictive of legislative attention by estimating a within-legislator relationship between campaign priorities and legislative priorities in the proceeding Congress. The equation is as follows:

$$f(\text{LegislativeActivity}_{ijt}) = \beta \text{CampaignAttention}_{ijt-1} + \alpha_{it} + \phi_{jt} + \epsilon_i. \quad (3)$$

I consider two outcome variables represented by $f(\text{LegislativeActivity}_{ijt})$: an indicator for whether House member i sponsored any legislation pertaining to issue j during congress t , and the number of bills member i cosponsored on issue j in congress t . I use a binary specification of the sponsorship variable and a continuous specification of the cosponsorship variable because Figure 4 shows that the meaningful variation in sponsorship is in whether or not a member sponsored any bill, whereas the meaningful variation in cosponsorship is in how many bills a member cosponsored. The explanatory variable $\text{CampaignAttention}_{ijt-1}$ indicates whether legislator i campaigned on issue j in election year $t-1$, representing the election immediately preceding the legislative session in year t . Once again, α_{it} and ϕ_{jt} are respective legislator-year and issue-year fixed effects, which ensure that differences in legislators' effectiveness, institutional power, committee assignments, and overall productivity levels do not drive results so long as groups respond similarly to them across issues j . As such, β estimates the within-legislator-year differences in (co)sponsorship activity on issues prioritized versus ignored in the prior campaign, while also accounting for issue-specific time trends.

Table 4 reports results from Equation 3 estimated separately for freshmen and non-freshmen legislators, as the former indicates whether patterns hold among the new legis-

Table 4. Relationship Between Campaign Issue Attention and Subsequent Legislative Activity on Issue

	DV: Sponsored Bill (0/1)		DV: # Bills Co-Sponsored	
	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen
Campaigned on Issue $t-1$	0.051*** (0.015)	0.097*** (0.027)	2.183*** (0.304)	2.248*** (0.405)
Member-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	6,894	1,827	6,894	1,827
Unique Candidates	386	202	386	202
Unique Districts	311	175	311	175

Note: Observations are member–issue–year. Member–clustered standard errors in parentheses.
 $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

lators upon which Table 3 relies while the latter is informative of whether patterns hold among legislators more generally.²⁸ Legislators tend to be more active on their previous campaign issues, with the relationship being especially strong among freshmen. Campaigning on an issue is associated with an increase in the likelihood of introducing legislation on the issue of 10 percentage points among freshmen and five percentage points among non-freshmen, as well as cosponsoring between two and three additional bills on the issue for both. Members therefore appear to follow through on their campaign rhetoric by devoting greater legislative activity to the issues they championed in their campaign platforms than on issues they ignored.

The relationship between campaign and legislative attention shown in Table 4 raises the question of whether the greater incumbency advantage in funding from groups related to issues championed as a non-incumbent in Table 3 is actually driven by legislative activity between last non-incumbent election and first re-election. I evaluate whether patterns appear consistent with this explanation by comparing the extent to which issue group funding responds to campaign rhetoric versus legislative activity:

²⁸ Appendix F reports results from all legislative analyses using number of issue words as the independent variable, a continuous specification of the sponsorship dependent variable, and a binary specification of the cosponsorship dependent variable.

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Contribute}_{ijt+1} = & \beta_1 \text{CampaignAttention}_{ijt-1} + \beta_2 \text{LegislativeActivity}_{ijt} + \\ & \beta_3 (\text{CampaignAttention}_{ijt-1} \times \text{LegislativeActivity}_{ijt}) + \alpha_{it} + \phi_{jt} + \epsilon_i. \end{aligned} \quad (4)$$

$\text{Contribute}_{ijt+1}$ takes the value of 1 if legislator i received any primary contributions from groups centered around issue j in election year $t+1$, the election immediately proceeding congress t . Legislator i 's campaign attention to issue j in previous election year $t-1$ is captured by $\text{CampaignAttention}_{ijt-1}$, while her binary sponsorship activity or number of bills cosponsored on issue j in congress t are represented by $\text{LegislativeActivity}_{ijt}$. Given fixed effects α_{it} and ϕ_{jt} and the presence of an interaction term, β_1 represents the within-legislator-year relationship between previously campaigning on an issue and receiving issue group contributions in the following election for issues upon which the legislator was not active. Conversely, β_2 represents the within-legislator relationship between legislative activity on an issue and subsequent contributions from issue groups in the absence of prior campaign attention. Lastly, β_3 captures any additive reward from issue groups for expending both campaign and legislative attention.²⁹

The results reported in Table 5 suggest that legislators' previous campaign attention to an issue exhibits a consistent relationship with their issue group funding despite accounting for legislative activity on the issue in the empirical specification.³⁰ Across all four models, campaigning without legislating on an issue is associated with a significant increase in the likelihood of receiving contributions from issue groups in the next primary election, with magnitudes ranging from 12 to 25 percentage point increases depending upon type of legislative activity and legislator seniority.

²⁹Similarly to the problem of "bad controls" (Angrist and Pischke 2009), the inclusion of both previous campaign attention and subsequent legislative activity on the right hand side of Equation 4 may attenuate β_1 toward zero, as Table 4 suggests that legislative activity on an issue can result from campaign attention to the issue.

³⁰Appendix F presents additional estimates from models using number of campaign platform issue words, number of bills sponsored, a binary specification of cosponsorship, and logged contributions.

Table 5. Legislative Issue Activity, Campaign Issue Attention, and Subsequent Issue Group Funding

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)			
	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen
Campaigned on Issue $t-1$	0.121*** (0.017)	0.186*** (0.029)	0.147*** (0.022)	0.253*** (0.037)
Sponsored Bill (0/1)	0.048* (0.019)	0.099** (0.035)		
Campaigned $\times$ Sponsored	0.001 (0.030)	-0.105* (0.047)		
# Bills Co-Sponsored			0.003** (0.001)	0.011*** (0.003)
Campaigned $\times$ Co-Sponsored			-0.002 (0.001)	-0.010** (0.003)
Member-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	5,463	1,512	5,463	1,512
Unique Candidates	302	167	302	167
Unique Districts	275	150	275	150

Note: Observations are member–issue–year. Member–clustered standard errors in parentheses.
p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

On the other hand, relationships between legislative activity and issue group fundraising appear to be weaker. For issues on which non–freshmen did not previously devote campaign attention, bill sponsorship is associated with under a 5 percentage point increase in likelihood of receiving contributions from issue groups — less than half the size of the coefficient associated with campaigning in the absence of sponsorship. Among freshmen, the estimated relationship between bill sponsorship and issue group support remains smaller than that of campaign attention and issue group support (although the two are not statistically distinct at traditional levels). Moreover, comparing increases in likelihood of receiving issue group support associated with binary campaign attention versus number of bills cosponsored implies that non–freshmen would need to cosponsor nearly 50 bills and freshmen would need to cosponsor almost 25 for relationships to be equivalent. Both freshmen and non-freshmen had the aforementioned median of 9 cosponsored bills at the legislator–issue–congress level conditional on cosponsorship activity, suggesting that the magnitude of campaign attention is quite large compared to

that of cosponsorship. Finally, the negative (and relatively large) coefficients on interaction terms in freshmen models suggest that there is no issue group funding advantage in engaging in both activities among first-term legislators. These results cast doubt on the idea that issue groups solely respond to campaign rhetoric due to its relationship with legislative activity and, if anything, suggest that groups' contributions are more responsive to campaign attention than to legislative attention on their issue.

Discussion and Conclusion

Single-issue interest groups are some of the most recognizable organizations active in American elections, receiving millions of dollars in congressional races each election cycle from members of the public who ostensibly share the groups' priorities. Despite their ubiquity, little is known about issue groups' contribution strategies with regard to the factor which distinguishes them from other moneyed interests: prioritization of a salient issue. Leveraging original data on campaign platforms drawn from House primary candidates' websites, I provide systematic evidence that candidates are more likely to receive contributions from groups related to their campaign issues. While issue groups appear to strongly value access to sitting legislators, my analyses suggest that they rely on campaign rhetoric at the primary stage to identify and cultivate relationships with potential champions of their cause.

Why do issue groups seem to respond to a signal as ostensibly "cheap" as campaign rhetoric? While determining precise mechanisms remains beyond the scope of this paper, I have sought to shed light on which are least consistent the descriptive patterns in the data. First, I find little evidence of relationship reversal: platforms are relatively stable, candidates are no more likely to add issues of interest after receiving support from said issue's groups, contributions tend to arrive later in the primary period, and results hold when including only post-filing contributions or selecting on platforms with stable

issue attention. Second, there is little support for the idea that groups only respond to campaign rhetoric as a proxy for immediate past or future behavior that groups actually value. The relationship holds among non-incumbents and first-time congressional candidates, and while campaign priorities predict legislative priorities, the greater support that candidates receive from groups related to their campaign priorities after successful election to Congress is not explained by legislative activity: if anything, groups are more responsive to campaign attention to their issue than legislative attention.

While these analyses do not constitute direct nor causal evidence of groups valuing campaign rhetoric for its own sake, they do cut against some of the most plausible alternative mechanisms for the relationship between campaign attention and issue group funding. Overall, the evidence appears more consistent with campaign attention providing independent value or a signal of longer-term issue championship to groups. Issue groups' apparent responsiveness to campaign attention over legislative activity on their issue may also shed light on conflicting findings regarding the feasibility of long-term alliances between politicians and organized interests (McCarty and Rothenberg 1996; Snyder 1992). Advancing a formal model which offered a resolution to this debate, Hall and Deardorff (2006) concluded that "money buys access only to one's allies, and the behavioral consequence is greater legislative effort on behalf of a shared objective" (80). However, given the preclusion of meaningful progress for legislation on controversial issues during eras of unorthodox and partisan lawmaking, simply having a strong ally with shared priorities is likely the best for which many issue groups can hope in a given Congress (Cox and McCubbins 2005; Lee 2016; Sinclair 2016).

Beyond the scope of this paper, the data introduced here highlights the potential for new avenues of research which can extend, build upon, and further clarify our understanding of the role of issue agendas in congressional elections. Future work could capture not just candidate-group alignment in issue prioritization, but leverage prominent issue groups' public stances to directly measure candidate-group proximity (e.g. Lyon, Mal-

colm, and Dickerson 2001). And while these analyses focus solely on direct contributions, which are just one of multiple financial levers interest groups have at their disposal to attempt to influence policymaking. Given recent work demonstrating the systemic and sequential links between groups' potential avenues of influence, subsequent research should examine whether issue groups also engage in lobbying and making independent expenditures on behalf of those who have rhetorically prioritized an issue in their campaigns, as well as whether these activities appear complementary or substitutable (Kim, Stuckatz, and Wolters 2025).

More broadly, this work contributes to a number of literatures which are only gaining importance due to recent trends in American politics. While moneyed interests' motivations have traditionally been viewed through the lens of access versus partisanship and ideology, the results presented here advance ongoing efforts to illuminate the heterogeneity of strategy and motivations among both organized interests and individual donors (Barber, Canes-Wrone, and Thrower 2017; Crosson, Furnas, and Lorenz 2020; Grumbach 2020; Gordon, Hafer, and Landa 2007; Li 2018; Stuckatz 2022). Moreover, I focus on issue groups' strategies during primaries, the stage of the election which is becoming increasingly consequential for electoral outcomes and where existing theoretical work suggests groups may be able to exercise the most influence (Bawn et al. 2012). In doing so, this paper joins a growing body of work (e.g. Blum and Cowburn 2023; Hirano and Snyder 2019; Meisels 2026, 2025; Thomsen 2023) elucidating the unique dynamics of intraparty elections, for which well-established theories of elections tend to have less traction.

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Appendix

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A Issue Selection

I identified PACs coded by OpenSecrets with an “Ideological/Single-Issue” (versus “Labor” or “Business”) sector code which made any primary-designated contributions in House elections in 2016, 2018, 2020, or 2022. Because OpenSecrets data are not yet available for 2024, I included all previously coded PACs and supplemented these with any new PACs who contributed to the 2024 sample candidates and met the below criteria based on either the PAC’s name, or — if the name was uninformative — their organization’s public documents, when available. I then dropped PACs with general ideological, leadership PAC, and candidate committee OpenSecrets industry codes as these are not centered around one single issue. Next, I used industry codes and organization names to drop PACs associated with issue areas insufficiently broad or narrow to feasibly be campaigned upon by some but not all candidates across the nation, as well as those with primarily electoral or representational goals rather than policy goals.

Within OpenSecrets’ “Women’s Issues” industry code, for example, many organizations such as Women Under Forty PAC leverage contributions in order to increase the number of women legislators, young women legislators, or women legislators of a certain party — a primary aim distinct from that of championing a particular issue. In contrast, abortion-centric organizations center a particular issue that some may consider a “women’s issue.” Likewise, while a number of PACs devoted to particular foreign policy matters exist, many of these (such as anti-Castro organization US-Cuba Democracy PAC) pertain to issues that are campaigned upon by vanishingly few candidates. However, organizations related to policy and treatment toward Israel are included, as the US’ partnership with Israel and geopolitical issues pertaining to Israel make the issue salient enough for candidates across the country to feasibly adopt stances on it.

Additionally, I exclude issues for which the main organized interests are primarily oriented toward furthering their members’ material interests, such as trade organizations and unions. These include agriculture, education, labor, and corporate business.

B Issue Groups

Table B1. Included Issue PACs

PAC Name	Issue
National Rifle Assn	Guns
NARAL Pro-Choice America	Abortion
Desert Caucus	Israel
Citizens Organized PAC	Israel
Americans United in Support of Democracy	Israel
Safari Club International	Guns
Florida Congressional Cmte	Israel
Minnesota Citizens Concerned for Life	Abortion
Sierra Club	Environment

To Protect Our Heritage PAC	Israel
Washington PAC	Israel
Americans for Good Government	Israel
Joint Action Cmte for Political Affairs	Israel
Friends of the Earth	Environment
Illinois Right to Life	Abortion
Louisianans for American Security	Israel
National Action Cmte	Israel
National PAC	Israel
Mid Manhattan PAC	Israel
National Cmte to Preserve Social Security	Elderly
City PAC	Israel
EMILY's List	Abortion
Maryland Assn for Concerned Citizens	Israel
Bi-County PAC	Israel
Human Rights Campaign	LGBTQ
League of Conservation Voters	Environment
New Jersey Right to Life	Abortion
Gun Owners of America	Guns
Illinois Citizens for Life	Abortion
Planned Parenthood	Abortion
Ohio Gun Collectors Assn	Guns
Susan B Anthony List	Abortion
Republican Jewish Coalition	Israel
Republican Majority for Choice	Abortion
Grass Roots NC/Forum for Firearms Educ	Guns
National Pro-Life Alliance	Abortion
Washington Women for Choice	Abortion
SunPAC	Israel
Because I Care PAC	Israel
Ocean Champions	Environment
New Jersey Republican Pro-Life Coalition	Abortion
Log Cabin Republicans	LGBTQ
Texas Right to Life	Abortion
Protectseniors.org	Elderly
Center for Coastal Conservation	Environment
Alliance for Retired Americans	Elderly
JStreetPAC	Israel
Environment America	Environment
National Gun Rights PAC	Guns
Humane Society Legislative Fund	Animal Rights
Environmental Defense Action Fund	Environment

Grand Canyon State Caucus	Israel
National Wildlife Federation Action Fund	Environment
LGBTQ Victory Fund	LGBTQ
National Shooting Sports Foundation	Guns
National Assn for Gun Rights	Guns
Tri-State Maxed Out Women	Abortion
American Principles	Israel
L PAC	LGBTQ
Pro-Life PAC	Abortion
Giffords PAC	Guns
NRDC Action Fund	Environment
Equality PAC	LGBTQ
America's Conservation PAC	Environment
I-PAC JAX	Israel
LGBT Democrats of Virginia	LGBTQ
Population Connection	Abortion
American Unity Fund	LGBTQ
MaggiePAC	Abortion
End Citizens United	Campaign Finance
Voter Education PAC	Abortion
Sustainable Energy & Environment Coalition	Environment
Pride Fund to End Gun Violence	Guns
Americans For Law Enforcement	Police
Partnership for Conservation	Environment
White Coat Waste	Animal Rights
Sanctity of Life PAC	Abortion
Protect Life PAC	Abortion
Action Coalition PAC	Abortion
Social Security Works	Elderly
Everytown for Gun Safety Action Fund	Guns
Protect Our Future	Abortion
Citizens for Law Enforcement	Police
Democratic Conservation Alliance	Environment
Brady PAC	Guns
Sunrise PAC	Environment
Animal Wellness Action	Animal Rights
Energy Innovation PAC	Environment
Pro-Israel America PAC	Israel
Democratic Majority for Israel	Israel
Equality California Majority Fund	LGBTQ
End the Occupation	Israel
JVP Action	Israel

American Horse PAC	Animal Rights
Fannie Lou Hamer PAC	Abortion
C6 Project	Environment
Americans for Action On Climate Fund	Environment
End the New Apartheid	Israel
End Litter Now PAC	Environment
Wilderness Society Action Fund	Environment
American Israel Public Affairs Cmte	Israel
Jane Fonda Climate PAC	Environment

C Campaign Platform Collection

Identifying relevant candidates. I identified all candidates who appeared on a Republican or Democratic primary ballot in each district in 2016, 2018, 2020, 2022, and 2024. Independent, write-in, and dropout candidates were excluded, as well as candidates who ran in the primaries in the table below, and candidates whose primaries were canceled. Overall, the target population includes 7,087 candidate-year observations.

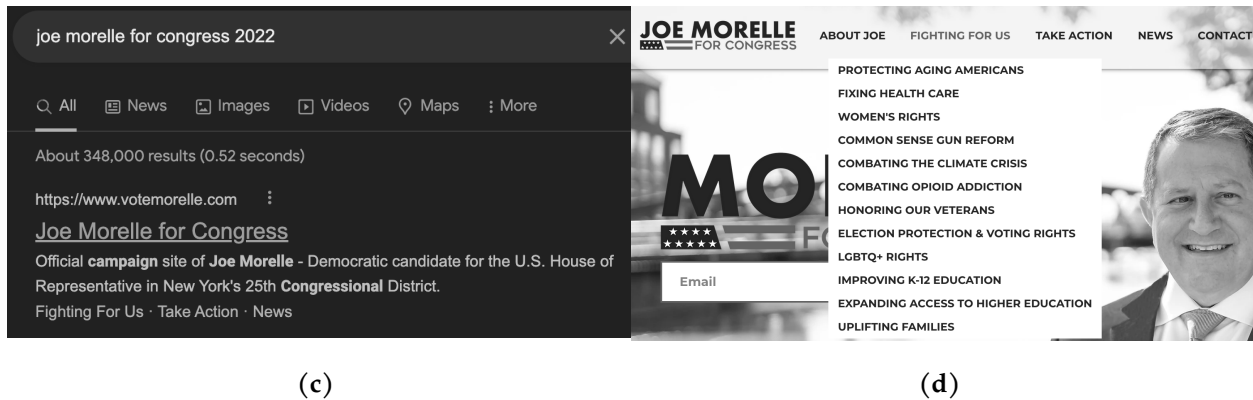
Table C1. Excluded Primary Races

Locale	Reason
Alaska, 2022 and 2024	Top-4
California	Top-2
Connecticut	Party Convention
Louisiana	Top-2
Utah	Party Convention
Virginia, 2016, Democratic: Districts 5,7,1,6,9,10	Party Convention
Virginia, 2016, Republican: Districts 3,8,5,11,7	Party Convention
Virginia, 2018, Democratic: District 5	Party Convention
Virginia, 2018, Republican: District 5,8,3,7,6	Party Convention
Virginia, 2020, Democratic: District 9	Party Convention
Virginia, 2020, Republican: District 8,5,10,11,4,7	Party Convention
Virginia, 2022, Republican: District 8,5,10,11	Party Convention
Washington	Top-2

Source: Footnotes of FEC primary date calendars.

Searching for campaign websites in real time. As depicted in Figure C1, data on 2022 and 2024 primary candidates were collected in real time. Candidates' web pages were accessed as immediately as possible before their primary, always within a week of the election date. I first performed a web search for "[candidate name] for Congress [election year]". Official governmental websites and social media sites were ignored. If no website appearing to be the candidate's campaign website appeared in the first page of search results, I added the district (e.g. "AL-1") to the search terms. If nothing appeared, I then

Figure C1. Example Data Collection Workflow
(a) (b)



consulted Politics1.com and Ballotpedia.com, which compile fairly reliable lists of candidates' campaign websites at various levels of government. If no non-social media website or non-governmental campaign website was found, I moved on to the next candidate. Although it is possible that some campaign websites could have eluded this data collection process, it is fair to assume that issue groups and other observers would have likewise been unable to find them.

Searching for archived campaign websites. For candidates who ran in 2016, 2018, and 2020, the process was identical to that outlined above, with an added step of accessing the archived website as it appeared at the relevant time via the Wayback Machine (archive.org). I first performed a web site for "[candidate name] for Congress [election year]". Some candidates ran in more recent elections and maintained a new website at the same URL which hosted their campaign website during the election year of interest. Because many candidates delete their campaign websites after losing election, I likewise consulted historic versions of Politics1.com and Ballotpedia.com. Once a potential historic campaign website URL was identified, I pasted it into the Wayback Machine and accessed the snapshot of the website most immediately before the date of the primary. While these archives ranged in time from very close to the primary to months before the primary, I also recorded the date of the archive version.

Identifying issue positions. The vast majority of campaign websites had clearly delineated pages or sections for policy platforms, issue positions, or candidate priorities. If the area devoted to positions was not readily obvious in the website architecture, I sur-

veyed the entirety of the website for other places where one might find issue positions. I do not consider candidate biographies, endorsement lists, campaign updates, or volunteer/donation pages to be issue positions. Many incumbent candidates (and some candidates with state legislative experience) devoted a section of the website to their legislative achievements, and these were nearly always separate from issue position pages. I excluded pages devoted exclusively to legislative achievements, but some candidates relate positions on their issue pages to legislative achievements, all of which I include as issue positions. If a campaign website with issue position content was successfully accessed, the URL was recorded in a spreadsheet.

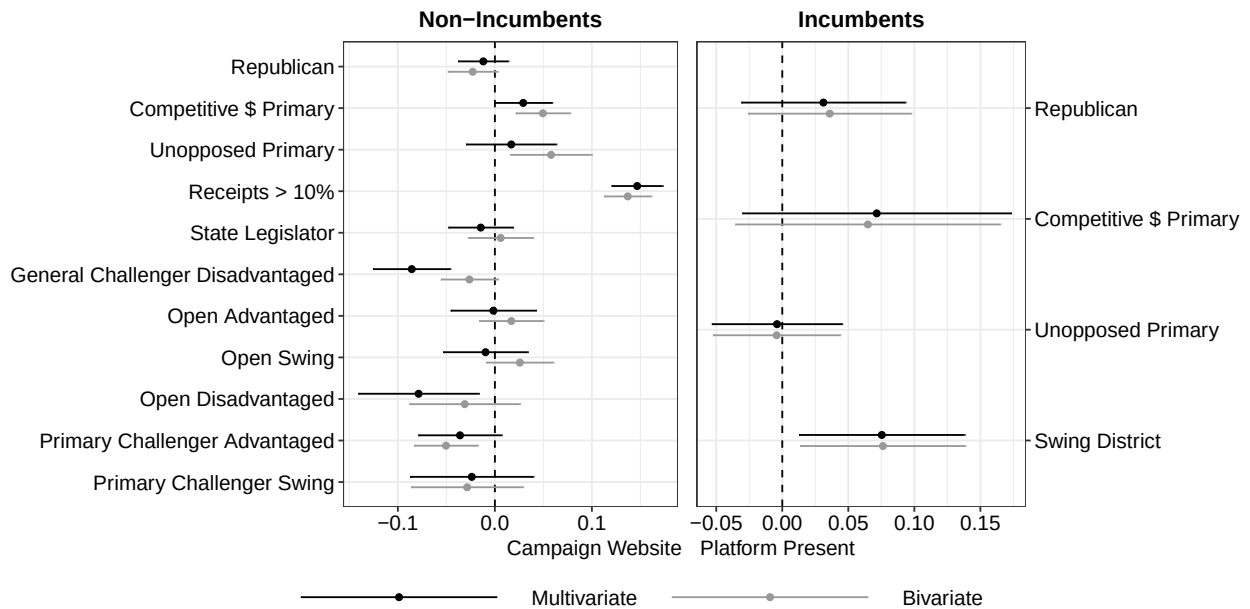
Collecting issue position text. Once issue position content was identified, I manually copied and pasted all of the associated positioning text — including the section header, issue stances, and candidate quotes — from each sub-issue page or section into one .txt file titled the candidate’s name and election year. I also captured the website content exactly as it appeared with a combination of manual screen capture and automated screen capture via the Awesome Screenshot extension on Google Chrome.

Representativeness. Overall, 5,311 candidates hosted websites with campaign platforms, yielding 75% coverage of the target population of 7,087 candidate-year observations. To investigate the representativeness of the sample population, Figure C2 plots point estimates and 95% confidence intervals based on candidate-clustered standard errors from multivariate and bivariate linear probability models predicting whether candidates had nonmissing campaign website platforms. Regressions are run separately by incumbency status, as missingness among incumbents is nearly always due to hosting a campaign website without any policy platform content whereas missingness among non-incumbents was nearly always due to an absence of a campaign website altogether.

Incumbents are about 8 percentage points more likely to include a campaign platform on their website if they are running in a swing district. Non-incumbents are more likely to have a campaign website with a platform if they raised more than a *de minimis* share of their primary field’s total funds, and less likely if they are running in a district where their party is likely disadvantaged in the general election. Overall, the results do not suggest that large swaths of candidates are systematically excluded from data on campaign agendas on the basis of candidate type, electoral competitiveness, or even resources.

Observation counts in main results. Given the target population of 7,087 candidates described in the first point of this Appendix, Table 1 includes the 5,311 candidate-year observations where a campaign website with a platform was hosted. With nine issue-wise observations across each candidate-year entry, this yields the maximum observation count of 47,999 found in Table 1. The models that include district-issue fixed effects drop one candidate-year singleton arising from just one unique candidate (with a platform) running in the district over the sample period, which decreases the observation count down to 47,990 -after dropping the one candidate’s nine issue-wise observations in the one year in which they appeared on a primary ballot. Table 2 breaks these same 47,999 observations into subgroups by candidate type and district lean. While Tables 1 and 2 impose no time series requirement on candidates entering the sample, the analyses reported in Table 3 require that candidates run and host campaign platforms in at least two consecutive years, excludes candidates who were always incumbents, and keeps only the first re-election run for those who eventually become incumbents. Whereas Table 1 includes

Figure C2. Predicting Campaign Website Platform Presence



4,082 unique candidates, these criteria restrict the sample in Table 3 to 538 unique candidates. Of the original 47,999, Table 4 includes the 8,721 candidate-year-issue observations where candidates were successfully elected to Congress from 2016 to 2022, as legislative activity is still ongoing for those who won election in 2024. Table 5 includes the subset of Table 4 observations where legislators then subsequently ran for re-election (and hosted a campaign platform). These unique candidate numbers are lower primarily due to cases of parties canceling unopposed primary elections.

D Timing and Relationship Reversal

D.1 Campaign Attention Following Issue PAC Contributions

Figure D1. Net Campaign Issue Word Change By Previous Issue PAC Funding

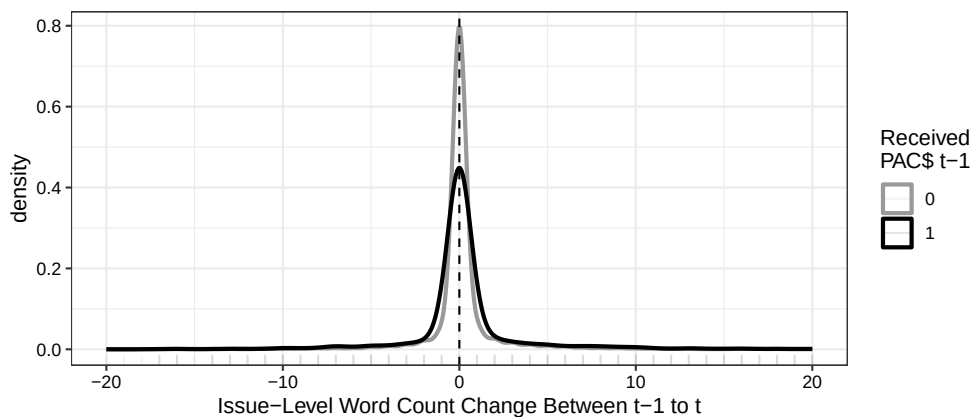


Figure D2. Rate of Campaign Issue Addition By Previous Issue PAC Funding

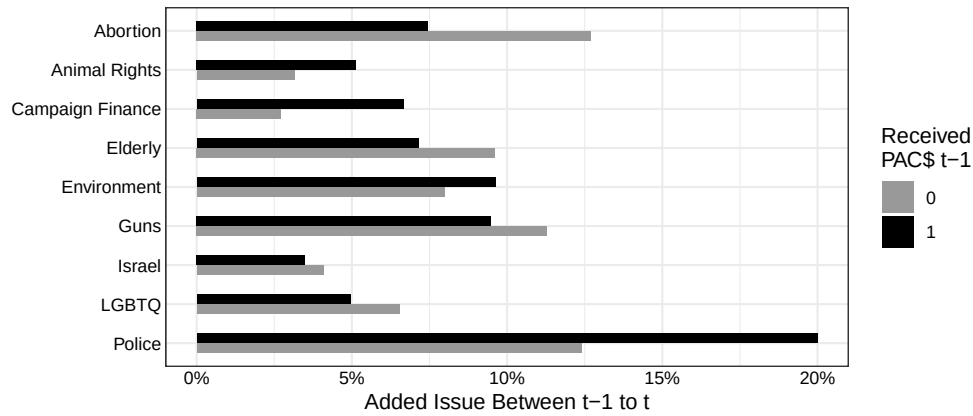


Table D1. Reverse Causality: Issue Group Financial Support and Change in Issue Attention

	DV: Added Issue From t-1 to t	DV: Issue Word Count Change From t-1 to t
Received Issue PAC \$ at t-1	0.009 (0.008)	0.059 (0.143)
Candidate FE	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓
Observations	9,909	9,909
Unique Candidates	681	681
Unique Districts	302	302

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

D.2 Issue PAC Contribution Timing

Figure D3. Timing of Issue PAC Contributions Relative to Primary Date

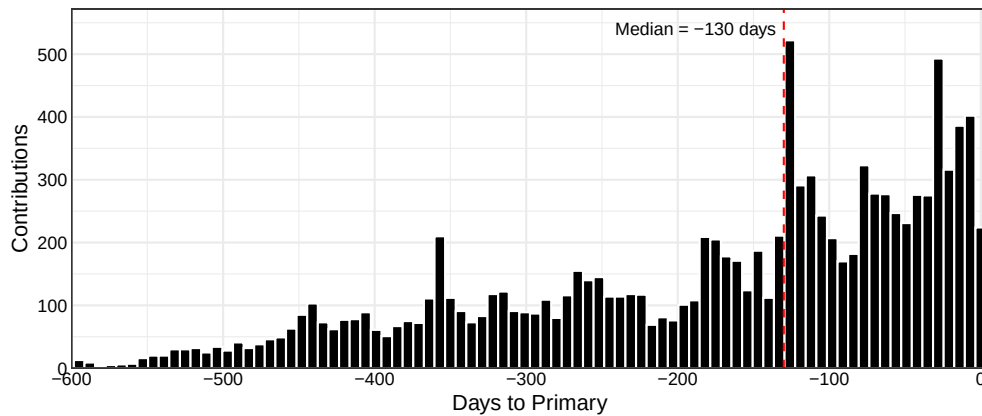
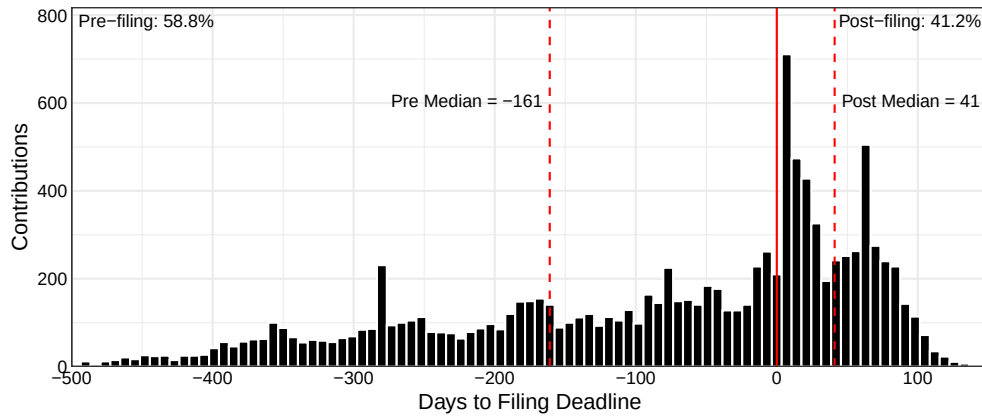


Figure D4. Timing of Issue PAC Contributions Relative to Filing Deadline**Table D2.** Robustness of Relationship Between Issue Attention and Financial Support from Issue Groups: Contributions Received After Filing Deadline and Stable Attention to Issues Only

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)	
	Post Filing Deadline Contribution	Stable Issue Attention
Campaigned on Issue	0.018*** (0.003)	0.086*** (0.009)
Candidate-Year FE	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓
Observations	47,799	15,284
Unique Candidates	4,082	924
Unique Districts	363	335

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table D3. Results From Cases with Reduced Incentives for Forward-Looking Contributions Meant for General Election

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)	
	Non-Incumbent in Contested Primary	Primary in District Safe for Party
Campaigned on Issue	0.016*** (0.002)	0.051*** (0.006)
Candidate-Year FE	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓
Observations	34,731	18,828
Unique Candidates	3,479	1,521
Unique Districts	361	293

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

E Campaign Issues

E.1 Issue Dictionary Construction

To identify whether each platform mentions the issues of interest, I construct issue dictionaries, or collections of terms indicating discussion of each issue. My approach is similar in spirit to the algorithmic approach for topic classification proposed by King, Lam, and Roberts (2017), yet considerably simpler. Their approach is motivated by the fact that “although humans perform very poorly in the task of *recalling* large numbers of words from memory, they excel at *recognizing* whether any given word is an appropriate representation of a given concept” (pg. 972). In other words, simply generating a set of terms related to each issue of interest from memory will lead to a biased and suboptimal set of keywords for identifying whether each document relates to the issue. As a solution, they propose having a computer assist in producing a list of potentially relevant terms from sample texts, from which a human then selects terms indicative of the topic without needing to recall terms themselves.

My approach differs in that producing the list of terms for review involves considerably less researcher discretion than in their approach. King, Lam, and Roberts (2017) partition their corpus into a reference set of documents solely representing the topic of interest and a search set of documents to be classified. Then, after imposing a threshold on how frequently terms must appear in the corpus, researchers select classifier(s) to be used for identifying terms which maximally discriminate between training sets sampled from the reference and search sets. The classification context in King, Lam, and Roberts (2017) differs from mine in two critical ways.

First, their documents are social media posts, which are short and tend to focus on one topic at a time, whereas my documents are entire platforms which contain content explicitly spanning multiple issues. For this reason, it is not possible to simply divide my corpus into sets of reference documents and search documents and then identify terms which best discriminate them, as they will differ across many topics orthogonal to the topic of interest. Second, their broader universe of documents — i.e. all social media posts — is so large that additional criteria are necessary to identify a more focused search set. Even after doing so, the wide variation in topics discussed in social media posts may make it infeasible to perform the human recognition task on the full list of tokens, even after setting a *de minimus* frequency threshold. In contrast, my corpus is much smaller and all documents are focused on political and policy issues, consisting of just a few thousand unique tokens which appear across at least 100 platforms. As a result, I am able to perform the human recognition task on the full set of tokens above this minimal frequency threshold.

E.2 Issue Keyword Dictionaries and Examples

Abortion Terms: "sanctity of life", "unborn", "pro-life", "fetus", "abortion", "abort", "noral", "global gag", "planned parenthood", "terminate", "rape", "right to life", "right to choose", "pro-choice", "pregnancy", "roe", "hyde", "family planning", "reproductive"

Abortion Example: “Women’s reproductive rights are under assault by the Trump Administration. A woman’s right to choose is a healthcare issue and economic empowerment issue, which is why it is crucial that we take action to protect women’s rights and reproductive freedom. Marilyn strongly supports a woman’s right to choose and will fight attempts to restrict access to birth control and women’s healthcare. In Congress, she will protect funding for Planned Parenthood and access to birth control, and will fiercely oppose attempts to overturn Roe v. Wade.” — Marilyn Strickland (WA-10-2020)

Gun Terms: "2nd amendment", "infringe", "right to bear arms", "militia", "second amendment", "self-defense", "nra", "rifle", "rifles", "ammunition", "firearm", "firearms", "gun violence", "shooting", "shootings", "shooter", "assault rifle", "automatic rifle", "automatic rifles", "automatic weapons", "assault weapon", "automatic weapon", "background checks", "background check", "bump stock", "high-capacity magazine", "gun", "guns", "high-capacity magazines"

Guns Example: “When it comes to protecting our right to bear arms, there has been no greater champion than Matt. Marion Hammer, past President of the NRA, has called Matt “one of the most pro-gun members of the Florida Legislature.” Matt successfully sponsored legislation banning local governments from infringing on our 2nd Amendment rights, and led the fight to bring Open Carry to Florida. When many called for the repeal of Florida’s Stand Your Ground Law, Matt fought to ensure that “not one damn comma” of the law was changed. Matt killed all taxes on gun club memberships, and passed legislation stopping insurance companies from discriminating against gun owners. Matt is once again leading the fight for our 2nd Amendment Rights in Congress by cosponsoring nationwide Concealed Carry Reciprocity legislation.” — Matt Gaetz (FL-1-2018)

Animal Terms: "animal", "animals", "pet", "pets"

Animal Example: “I would also champion the promotion of humane animal treatment. I would fight to make sure the next President enforces, funds, and keeps in place current protections for animals and wildlife. I’d work to close loopholes like those in the Marine Mammal Protection Act, and others designed to benefit the few and risk animals and their habitats. And we need to establish and enforce stronger regulations on puppy mills and other inhumane commercial breeding facilities. Our pets are members of our families, and wildlife are an important part of our ecosystem. I am currently the mom of a dog named Winston, and have had pets throughout my entire childhood. As a child, I volunteered at Free Flight Exotic Bird Sanctuary, Helen Woodward Animal Center, and beach clean ups, in addition to supporting conservation efforts and taking wildlife classes at the San Diego Zoo. I would bring this lifelong commitment to our environment, animals, and wildlife, which I know so many people in the 53rd District also share, to my work in Congress.” — Sara Jacobs (CA-53-2020)

LGBTQ Terms: "religious freedom", "marriage equality", "traditional marriage", "same sex marriage", "same-sex marriage", "traditional marriages", "same-sex marriage", "gay", "same sex", "same-sex", "sexual orientation",

"lgbt+", "lgbt", "lgbtq", "lgbtq+", "transgend", "sanctity of marriage", "conversion therapy", "gender affirming", "gender-affirming"

LGBTQ Example: “I believe that marriage is between one man and one woman. It is important to our culture that it be defined as such. I believe in a constitutional amendment that would protect traditional marriage. Why is a constitutional amendment necessary? It is necessary because of the increasing number of liberal state legislatures pushing for state laws that permit unconventional marriage to occur, and activist judges are sanctioning those laws with increasing regularity. The attack on traditional marriage is an attack on the fundamental core of our society.” — Charles Fleischmann (TN-3-2016)

Elderly Terms: "senior", "seniors", "retiring", "retired", "retire", "retires", "retirees", "retirement", "older americans", "old-age", "old age"

Elderly Example: “In Congress, I will always honor our commitments to seniors and protect the Social Security and Medicare programs that they have worked hard to fund. I oppose voucher schemes and support reforms that will ensure appropriate cost of living adjustments that account for the rising costs our seniors face. I’ve fought hard to improve service and cut costs by supporting efforts backed by the AARP and other organizations that represent older Americans. I was named a Medicare Advantage Champion by the Coalition for Medicare Choices, and I will continue these efforts to provide our most valued citizens with the health care and peace of mind they deserve. I’ve also advocated for a Caregiver’s Tax Credit to help families give their elderly loved ones the attention they need in the comfort of home. This effort is strongly supported by the AARP because it provides a tax credit for qualifying caregivers and recognizes the enormous contribution they make to their families and our healthcare system.” — Donald Norcross (NJ-1-2020)

Israel Terms: "israel", "israeli", "palestine", "palestinian", "israeli-palestinian"

Israel Example: “Israel is one of our strongest allies not only in the Middle East region but across the globe. Under President Trump, American-Israeli relations made great progress, but the Democrats in Congress and the Biden Administration threaten our partnership. With anti-Semitic activities on the rise, both nationally and in New York, it is the duty of our elected officials to properly and swiftly defend our allies. When he gets to Congress, Robert will join the fight to eradicate hate in all forms starting with his efforts to: Push legislation that clearly defines antisemitism and constructs clear punishments for those found engaging in antisemitic activities. Reaffirm and support legislation that maintains funding for Israel, our strongest ally in the Middle East and a beacon of democracy in the region. Fight back against the Radical Left’s crusade against Israeli sovereignty and their efforts to villainize American Jews. As we’ve seen across Long Island, New York, and the United States, anti-semitic activities and anti-Israeli sentiments are on the rise. We need to remember who our allies are and to make sure those relationships are reaffirmed. While in Congress, Cap will be vocal in standing by Israel and her right to protect the Israeli people from any outside influence or attacks.” — Robert Cornicelli (NY-2-2022)

Campaign Finance Terms: "citizens united", "campaign finance", "financial disclosure"

Campaign Finance Example: “Raja opposes the unfettered influx of corporate and special interest money in politics made possible by the Supreme Court’s wrong-headed Citizens United decision. In Congress, Raja will work to make sure that the voices of working people and the poor aren’t drowned out by special interests. First, Raja supports a constitutional amendment to overturn the effects of Citizens United by stipulating that the rights guaranteed in the Constitution and Bill of Rights are only inherent to natural persons – not to corporations — and that spending unlimited money in elections is not the same as exercising free speech. Second, Raja will work to eliminate so-called “dark money” from our elections by requiring all organizations to disclose their contributions – including those that currently hide their activities by claiming they are for “social” or “educational” purposes. This huge loophole is enabling wealthy individuals and interest groups to hijack our elections without revealing their true identities or purpose. We must return transparency to our elections, so voters can know who is behind the ads and other spending designed to influence their vote. Third, Raja will push for campaign finance reforms that enables more citizens to participate in our democracy. He will advocate for increased public financing of elections, broader access to our public airwaves for credible candidates, and he will encourage such practices as matching funds for small donations to candidates who agree to spending-limits. This will empower ordinary voters and reduce the over-reliance on special interests that skews our politics in favor of the few over the many.” — Raja Krishnamoorthi (IL-8-2016)

Environment Terms: "clean energy", "environment", "environmental", "climate change", "global warming", "greenhouse", "pollution", "polluting", "pollutants", "polluters", "fossil fuel", "fossil fuels", "carbon", "clean fuel", "ecosystem", "planet", "solar energy", "solar panels"

Environment Example: “Our nation’s increasing need for energy must be addressed in ways that balance our economy with the stewardship of our environment. Striking this balance is one of the most vital issues facing the United States. Climate Change, as the experts have proven, is a real problem that requires pro-active solutions from the federal government. We need programs that help the private sector explore new business models that can deliver clean energy and energy efficiency at lower cost. If elected to Congress, I will seek out and support appropriate solutions that put our country on a realistic and sustainable path to address this challenge. We need to increase funding for research & development of sustainable energy sources, support tax credits for the development and production of renewable energy like solar, wind, and more efficient and electric vehicles, explore user fees to reduce pollution, and increase funding for mass transit. On a personal note, I grew up on the St. Clair River. Summers of boating, floating on the river in an inner tube, and the thrill of catching that big fish — be it perch, pickerel, bass or walleye – remain fresh in my memory. But the issue of protecting our fresh water supply is a serious one. The Great Lakes are a precious resource for our region and contain 20 percent of all freshwater on the planet. They face serious threats from invasive species,

toxins, water diversion, wetland destruction, sewage overflows and Climate Change. I am committed to working with all communities to protect this valued asset of our region.” — Debbie Dingell (MI-12-2020)

Police Terms: "defund the police", "abolish", "law enforcement", "policing", "back the blue", "police", "protect and serve", "profiling", "incarcer", "officer", "officers"

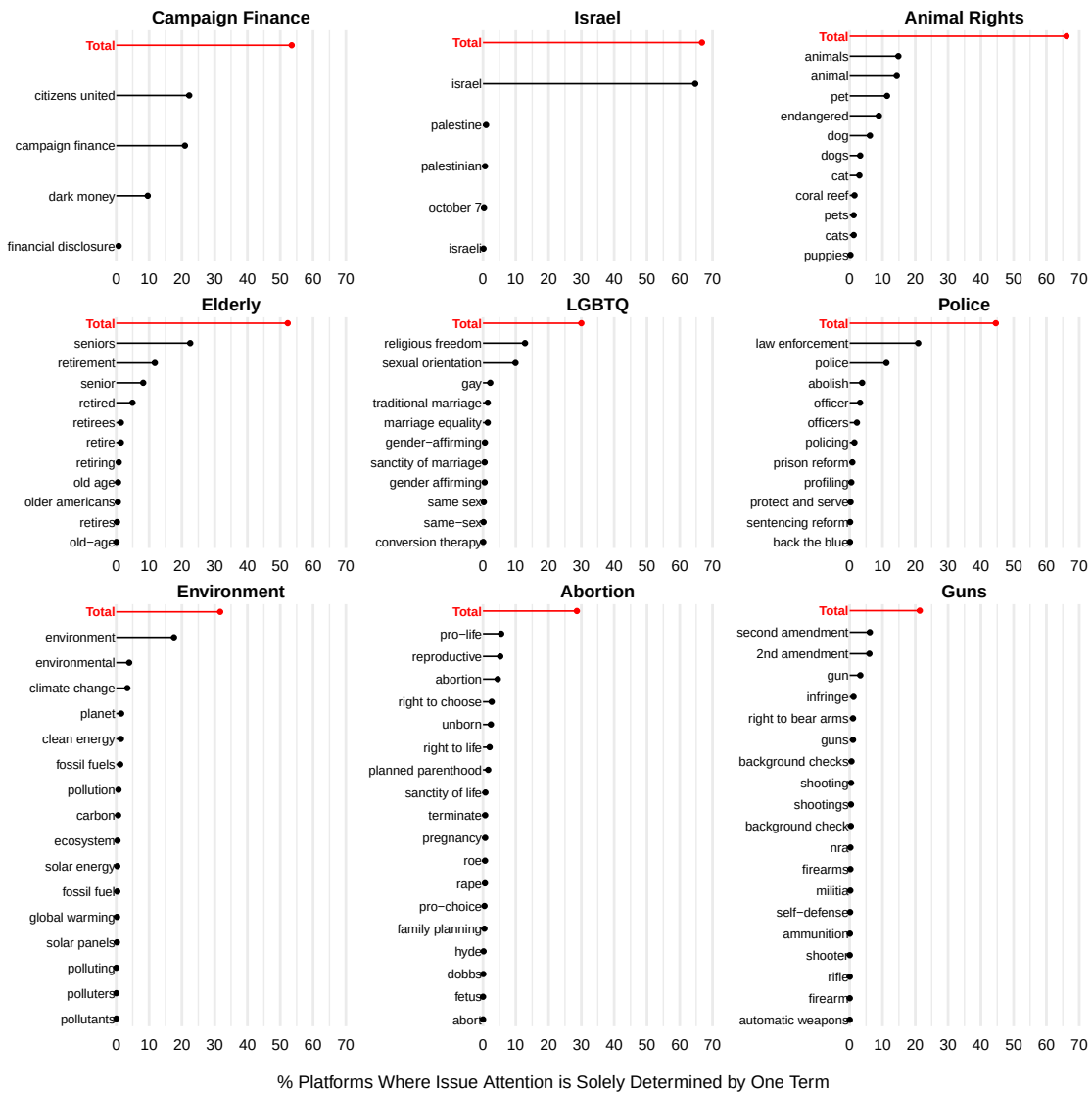
Police Example: “We can’t have Law & Order without law enforcement. We all have seen the movies where the bad guys have a certain respect for cops – the attitude of “don’t kill a cop” because the entire weight of law enforcement would come down and eliminate them. Sadly, since the Obama terms, law enforcement has been vilified, attacked, and disrespected to the point where law enforcement officers have actually been assassinated, and lured into ambushes for harm. Never in my life have I seen this until the last few years. Most law enforcement is at the State and local levels. However, I will do my part to ensure that Federal and local law enforcement work together – one team, one dream! I will publically support law enforcement to renew the respect and honor they deserve. Be vocal!” — Marvin Boguslawski (NC-6-2022)

E.3 Keyword Sensitivity Analysis

Because the main specifications rely on a binary measure of issue attention that takes a value of one whenever *any* dictionary term is matched in a platform, false positives are a substantially greater concern than false negatives. A leave-one-out sensitivity analysis is therefore a particularly appropriate validation exercise, as it assesses how often a candidate’s classification as attending to a given issue is solely determined by a single term in that issue’s dictionary. For each issue, I sequentially hold out each dictionary term and count the share of platforms whose word-presence indicator flips from one to zero, isolating cases where the held-out term was the only source of the classification. Figure E1 plots the share of platforms whose issue attention would change with the removal of each term, omitting terms whose removal has no impact; the red “Total” rows summarize the cumulative share of platforms whose classification on each issue rests on a single keyword.

The results indicate that issue attention would be unchanged by removing any one term from the issue dictionaries in the vast majority of cases, because most platforms that mention one issue-related term also mention others. The terms that do exhibit some leverage are exactly those we would hope and expect—for example, “israel” and “campaign finance” for their eponymous issues—which appear nearly verbatim in the conventional naming of the underlying concept. This pattern provides reassurance that the dictionary-based measure is not being driven by idiosyncratic keyword choices and that the issue attention classifications reflect substantive content rather than artifacts of dictionary construction.

Figure E1. Leave-one-out Sensitivity Analysis of Keyword Inclusion in Issue Dictionaries



F Alternative Specifications for Main Analyses

Table F1. Relationship Between Issue Attention and Financial Support from Issue Groups

	DV: Contribution (0/1)		DV: Cont. (0/1), Mixed Sample		DV: log(Contribution + 1)	
Campaigned on Issue	0.034*** (0.003)		0.107*** (0.012)		0.269*** (0.027)	
# Issue Words Used		0.002*** (0.000)		0.004** (0.002)		0.018*** (0.003)
Candidate-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
District-Issue FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	47,790	47,790	12,816	12,816	47,790	47,790
Unique Candidates	4,081	4,081	764	764	4,081	4,081
Unique Districts	362	362	320	320	362	362

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table F2. Relationship Between Issue Attention and Financial Support From Issue Groups by Candidate and District Type, Mixed Sample

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)					
	Incumbents		Open Seat		Challengers	
	Swing	Lean	Swing	Lean	Swing	Lean
Campaigned on Issue	0.153*** (0.019)	0.131*** (0.014)	0.132*** (0.038)	0.162*** (0.033)	0.083** (0.027)	0.113** (0.037)
Candidate-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,817	6,489	855	954	1,305	684

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table F3. Relationship Between Issue Attention and Financial Support From Issue Groups by Candidate and District Type, Logged DV

	DV: log(Issue Group Contribution + 1)					
	Incumbents		Open Seat		Challengers	
	Swing	Lean	Swing	Lean	Swing	Lean
Campaigned on Issue	1.206*** (0.150)	0.944*** (0.104)	0.186** (0.060)	0.144*** (0.042)	0.133*** (0.035)	0.057*** (0.016)
Candidate-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,934	6,867	5,058	7,065	9,666	16,209

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table F4. Relationship Between Issue Attention and Financial Support From Issue Groups by Candidate and District Type, Word Count

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)					
	Incumbents		Open Seat		Challengers	
	Swing	Lean	Swing	Lean	Swing	Lean
# Issue Words Used	0.011*** (0.003)	0.006* (0.002)	0.002* (0.001)	0.001* (0.001)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.001* (0.000)
Candidate-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,934	6,867	5,058	7,065	9,666	16,209

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table F5. Campaign Attention and Financial Support from Issue Groups Among First-Time Congressional Candidates Only

DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)	
Campaigned on Issue	0.014*** (0.002)
Observations	29,475
Unique Candidates	3,237
Unique Districts	360
Candidate-Year FE	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table F6. Relationship Between Issue Attention and Financial Support from National Issue Groups Only

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)							
Campaigned on Issue	0.052*** (0.004)	0.039*** (0.003)	0.053*** (0.005)	0.049*** (0.004)	0.037*** (0.004)	0.049*** (0.004)	0.033*** (0.003)	0.033*** (0.003)
Candidate-Year FE		✓			✓		✓	✓
Issue-Year FE			✓		✓	✓		✓
District-Issue FE				✓		✓	✓	✓
Observations	47,799	47,799	47,799	47,790	47,799	47,790	47,790	47,790
Unique Candidates	4,082	4,082	4,082	4,081	4,082	4,081	4,081	4,081
Unique Districts	363	363	363	362	363	362	362	362

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table F7. Relationship Between Campaign Issue Attention and Subsequent Legislative Activity on Issue, Alternative Specifications

	DV: # Bills Sponsored		DV: Co-Sponsored Bill (0/1)	
	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen
Campaigned on Issue t_{-1}	0.213*** (0.045)	0.220*** (0.046)	0.040*** (0.007)	0.053*** (0.012)
Member-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	6,894	1,827	6,894	1,827

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table F8. Relationship Between Campaign Issue Attention and Subsequent Legislative Activity on Issue, Word Count

	DV: Sponsored Bill (0/1)		DV: # Bills Co-Sponsored	
	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen
# Issue Words t_{-1}	0.008*** (0.002)	0.006* (0.003)	0.229*** (0.042)	0.312*** (0.046)
Member-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	6,894	1,827	6,894	1,827

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table F9. Legislative Issue Activity, Campaign Issue Attention, and Subsequent Issue Group Funding, Word Count

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)			
	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen
# Issue Words Used t_{-1}	0.006 (0.003)	0.000 (0.003)	0.009* (0.004)	0.010 (0.005)
Sponsored Bill (0/1)	0.051** (0.016)	0.066* (0.030)		
Words $\times$ Sponsored	0.000 (0.005)	-0.001 (0.003)		
# Bills Co-Sponsored			0.003** (0.001)	0.009*** (0.002)
Words $\times$ Co-Sponsored			0.000 (0.000)	-0.001** (0.000)
Member-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	5,463	1,512	5,463	1,512

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table F10. Legislative Issue Activity, Campaign Issue Attention, and Subsequent Issue Group Funding, Alternative Specifications

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)			
	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen
Campaigned on Issue $t-1$	0.117*** (0.016)	0.164*** (0.027)	0.092 (0.057)	0.322*** (0.078)
# Bills Sponsored	0.017 (0.010)	0.049** (0.018)		
Campaigned $\times$ Sponsored	0.005 (0.012)	-0.026 (0.021)		
Co-Sponsored Bill (0/1)			0.119*** (0.022)	0.270*** (0.040)
Campaigned $\times$ Co-Sponsored			0.029 (0.058)	-0.182* (0.078)
Member-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	5,463	1,512	5,463	1,512

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table F11. Legislative Issue Activity, Campaign Issue Attention, and Subsequent Issue Group Funding, Logged DV

	DV: $\log(\text{Issue Group Contribution} + 1)$			
	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen
Campaigned on Issue $t-1$	0.920*** (0.135)	1.557*** (0.222)	1.111*** (0.178)	2.121*** (0.291)
Sponsored Bill (0/1)	0.404** (0.144)	0.858** (0.290)		
Campaigned $\times$ Sponsored	-0.021 (0.234)	-0.880* (0.366)		
# Bills Co-Sponsored			0.022* (0.010)	0.077*** (0.022)
Campaigned $\times$ Co-Sponsored			-0.017 (0.012)	-0.078*** (0.022)
Member-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	5,463	1,512	5,463	1,512

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

G Results at the Candidate–PAC–Year Level

Table G1. Relationship Between Issue Attention and Financial Support from Issue Groups, Candidate-PAC-Year Level

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)							
Campaigned on Issue	0.006*** (0.001)	0.004*** (0.001)	0.007*** (0.001)	0.006*** (0.001)	0.005*** (0.001)	0.006*** (0.001)	0.004*** (0.001)	0.005*** (0.001)
Candidate-Year FE		✓			✓		✓	✓
PAC-Year FE			✓		✓	✓		✓
District-Issue FE				✓		✓	✓	✓
Observations	562,966	562,966	562,966	562,965	562,966	562,965	562,965	562,965
Unique Candidates	4,082	4,082	4,082	4,082	4,082	4,082	4,082	4,082
Unique Districts	363	363	363	363	363	363	363	363

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table G2. Relationship Between Issue Attention and Financial Support From Issue Groups by Candidate and District Type, Candidate-PAC-Year Level

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)					
	Incumbents		Open Seat		Challengers	
	Swing	Lean	Swing	Lean	Swing	Lean
Campaigned on Issue	0.025*** (0.004)	0.017*** (0.002)	0.002 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.003*** (0.001)	0.001** (0.000)
Candidate-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
PAC-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	34,556	80,878	59,572	83,210	113,844	190,906
Unique Candidates	195	358	553	776	990	1,631
Unique Districts	135	276	73	115	152	292

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table G3. Incumbency Advantage in Issue Group Financial Support By Prior Issue Attention, Candidate-PAC-Year Level

	DV: Contribution (0/1)	DV: log(Contribution + 1)
Incumbency	0.027** (0.008)	0.200** (0.067)
Campaigned on Issue $t-1$	0.005*** (0.001)	0.044*** (0.009)
Incumbency $\times$ Issue $t-1$	0.012** (0.004)	0.088** (0.033)
Candidate FE	✓	✓
PAC-Year FE	✓	✓
Observations	65,826	65,826
Unique Candidates	538	538
Unique Districts	266	266

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table G4. Legislative Issue Activity, Campaign Issue Attention, and Subsequent Issue Group Funding, Candidate-PAC-Year Level

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)			
	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen
Campaigned on Issue $t-1$	0.020*** (0.003)	0.036*** (0.005)	0.020*** (0.004)	0.053*** (0.007)
Sponsored Bill (0/1)	0.012*** (0.003)	0.023*** (0.007)		
Campaigned $\times$ Sponsored	-0.004 (0.005)	-0.018* (0.009)		
# Bills Co-Sponsored			0.001** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.000)
Campaigned $\times$ Co-Sponsored			0.000 (0.000)	-0.002*** (0.001)
Member-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
PAC-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	64,342	17,808	64,342	17,808
Unique Candidates	302	167	302	167
Unique Districts	275	150	275	150

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

H Heterogeneity: Results by Party

Table H1. Relationship Between Issue Attention and Financial Support from Issue Groups, Democrats Only

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)							
Campaigned on Issue	0.038*** (0.007)	0.021*** (0.005)	0.046*** (0.008)	0.032*** (0.007)	0.029*** (0.005)	0.031*** (0.006)	0.022*** (0.005)	0.023*** (0.005)
Candidate-Year FE		✓			✓		✓	✓
Issue-Year FE			✓		✓	✓		✓
District-Issue FE				✓		✓	✓	✓
Observations	21,519	21,519	21,519	21,447	21,519	21,447	21,447	21,447
Unique Candidates	1,871	1,871	1,871	1,863	1,871	1,863	1,863	1,863
Unique Districts	351	351	351	343	351	343	343	343

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table H2. Relationship Between Issue Attention and Financial Support from Issue Groups, Republicans Only

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)							
Campaigned on Issue	0.056*** (0.005)	0.056*** (0.005)	0.023*** (0.005)	0.010* (0.004)	0.015** (0.005)	0.013** (0.005)	0.002 (0.004)	0.006 (0.004)
Candidate-Year FE		✓			✓		✓	✓
Issue-Year FE			✓		✓	✓		✓
District-Issue FE				✓		✓	✓	✓
Observations	26,280	26,280	26,280	26,235	26,280	26,235	26,235	26,235
Unique Candidates	2,211	2,211	2,211	2,206	2,211	2,206	2,206	2,206
Unique Districts	339	339	339	334	339	334	334	334

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table H3. Incumbency Advantage in Issue Group Financial Support By Prior Issue Attention, Democrats Only

	DV: Contribution (0/1)	DV: log(Contribution + 1)
Incumbency	0.262*** (0.062)	1.951*** (0.469)
Campaigned on Issue t_{-1}	0.032* (0.014)	0.287* (0.117)
Incumbency $\times$ Issue t_{-1}	-0.069 (0.039)	-0.362 (0.320)
Candidate FE	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓
Observations	2,286	2,286
Unique Candidates	222	222
Unique Districts	167	167

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table H4. Incumbency Advantage in Issue Group Financial Support By Prior Issue Attention, Republicans Only

	DV: Contribution (0/1)	DV: log(Contribution + 1)
Incumbency	0.120* (0.059)	0.880 (0.490)
Campaigned on Issue t_{-1}	-0.022* (0.008)	-0.162* (0.067)
Incumbency $\times$ Issue t_{-1}	0.190*** (0.027)	1.499*** (0.205)
Candidate FE	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓
Observations	3,303	3,303
Unique Candidates	316	316
Unique Districts	209	209

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table H5. Relationship Between Campaign Issue Attention and Subsequent Legislative Activity on Issue, Democrats Only

	DV: Sponsored Bill (0/1)		DV: # Bills Co-Sponsored	
	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen
Campaigned on Issue t_{-1}	0.064** (0.023)	0.152*** (0.036)	1.298** (0.428)	0.924 (0.500)
Member-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,988	801	2,988	801
Unique Candidates	160	89	160	89
Unique Districts	150	83	150	83

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table H6. Relationship Between Campaign Issue Attention and Subsequent Legislative Activity on Issue, Republicans Only

	DV: Sponsored Bill (0/1)		DV: # Bills Co-Sponsored	
	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen
Campaigned on Issue t_{-1}	0.030 (0.020)	0.036 (0.045)	1.584*** (0.434)	2.234*** (0.647)
Member-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	3,906	1,026	3,906	1,026
Unique Candidates	226	113	226	113
Unique Districts	192	103	192	103

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table H7. Legislative Issue Activity, Campaign Issue Attention, and Subsequent Issue Group Funding, Democrats Only

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)			
	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen
Campaigned on Issue t_{-1}	0.020 (0.026)	0.020 (0.038)	0.032 (0.034)	0.008 (0.054)
Sponsored Bill (0/1)	0.069* (0.029)	0.010 (0.053)		
Campaigned $\times$ Sponsored	0.050 (0.041)	0.036 (0.066)		
# Bills Co-Sponsored			0.004* (0.002)	0.008 (0.004)
Campaigned $\times$ Co-Sponsored			0.000 (0.001)	0.001 (0.003)
Member-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,394	630	2,394	630
Unique Candidates	130	70	130	70
Unique Districts	128	66	128	66

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table H8. Legislative Issue Activity, Campaign Issue Attention, and Subsequent Issue Group Funding, Republicans Only

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)			
	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen	Non-Freshmen	Freshmen
Campaigned on Issue t_{-1}	0.047* (0.020)	0.082* (0.036)	0.094** (0.032)	0.098* (0.047)
Sponsored Bill (0/1)	0.026 (0.018)	0.046 (0.033)		
Campaigned $\times$ Sponsored	0.014 (0.030)	-0.070 (0.043)		
# Bills Co-Sponsored			0.010*** (0.002)	0.009* (0.004)
Campaigned $\times$ Co-Sponsored			-0.005 (0.003)	-0.005 (0.004)
Member-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Issue-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	3,069	882	3,069	882
Unique Candidates	172	97	172	97
Unique Districts	167	90	167	90

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

I Heterogeneity: Results by Issue

Table I1. Relationship Between Abortion Attention and Financial Support from Abortion Groups

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)		DV: log(Issue Group Contribution + 1)	
Campaigned on Issue	0.064*** (0.009)		0.497*** (0.075)	
# Issue Words Used		0.006*** (0.002)		0.045*** (0.012)
Party-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	5,311	5,311	5,311	5,311
Unique Candidates	4,082	4,082	4,082	4,082
Unique Districts	363	363	363	363

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table I2. Relationship Between Animal Rights Attention and Financial Support from Animal Rights Groups

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)		DV: log(Issue Group Contribution + 1)	
Campaigned on Issue	0.032 (0.019)		0.263 (0.149)	
# Issue Words Used		0.010 (0.006)		0.082 (0.047)
Party-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	5,311	5,311	5,311	5,311
Unique Candidates	4,082	4,082	4,082	4,082
Unique Districts	363	363	363	363

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table I3. Relationship Between Campaign Finance Attention and Financial Support from Campaign Finance Groups

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)		DV: log(Issue Group Contribution + 1)	
Campaigned on Issue	0.063*** (0.018)		0.523*** (0.146)	
# Issue Words Used		0.017** (0.006)		0.139** (0.049)
Party-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	5,311	5,311	5,311	5,311
Unique Candidates	4,082	4,082	4,082	4,082
Unique Districts	363	363	363	363

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table I4. Relationship Between Elderly Attention and Financial Support from Elderly Groups

	<i>DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)</i>		<i>DV: log(Issue Group Contribution + 1)</i>	
Campaigned on Issue	0.033*** (0.006)		0.235*** (0.045)	
# Issue Words Used		0.006** (0.002)		0.046** (0.014)
Party-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	5,311	5,311	5,311	5,311
Unique Candidates	4,082	4,082	4,082	4,082
Unique Districts	363	363	363	363

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table I5. Relationship Between Environment Attention and Financial Support from Environment Groups

	<i>DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)</i>		<i>DV: log(Issue Group Contribution + 1)</i>	
Campaigned on Issue	0.025** (0.009)		0.208** (0.066)	
# Issue Words Used		0.003** (0.001)		0.025** (0.008)
Party-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	5,311	5,311	5,311	5,311
Unique Candidates	4,082	4,082	4,082	4,082
Unique Districts	363	363	363	363

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table I6. Relationship Between Guns Attention and Financial Support from Guns Groups

	<i>DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)</i>		<i>DV: log(Issue Group Contribution + 1)</i>	
Campaigned on Issue	0.021 (0.012)		0.162 (0.099)	
# Issue Words Used		0.001* (0.001)		0.012* (0.005)
Party-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	5,311	5,311	5,311	5,311
Unique Candidates	4,082	4,082	4,082	4,082
Unique Districts	363	363	363	363

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table I7. Relationship Between Israel Attention and Financial Support from Israel Groups

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)		DV: log(Issue Group Contribution + 1)	
Campaigned on Issue	0.084*** (0.022)		0.757*** (0.190)	
# Issue Words Used		0.006* (0.002)		0.052* (0.020)
Party-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	5,311	5,311	5,311	5,311
Unique Candidates	4,082	4,082	4,082	4,082
Unique Districts	363	363	363	363

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table I8. Relationship Between LGBTQ Attention and Financial Support from LGBTQ Groups

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)		DV: log(Issue Group Contribution + 1)	
Campaigned on Issue	0.031** (0.012)		0.245** (0.094)	
# Issue Words Used		0.010*** (0.003)		0.081*** (0.025)
Party-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	5,311	5,311	5,311	5,311
Unique Candidates	4,082	4,082	4,082	4,082
Unique Districts	363	363	363	363

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table I9. Relationship Between Police Attention and Financial Support from Police Groups

	DV: Issue Group Contribution (0/1)		DV: log(Issue Group Contribution + 1)	
Campaigned on Issue	0.001 (0.002)		0.006 (0.015)	
# Issue Words Used		0.000 (0.000)		-0.001 (0.000)
Party-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	5,311	5,311	5,311	5,311
Unique Candidates	4,082	4,082	4,082	4,082
Unique Districts	363	363	363	363

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001